PASSPORT TIRTHA 2026–27

BAL GOKUL OF PRINCE WILLIAM COUNTY · 2026–27

Sacred Geography

Hindu Temples and Pilgrimage Places

Teacher Lesson Book · Grades 9–12

25 classes in 23 Sunday sessions · 30 minutes each · Alvey Elementary School, Haymarket, Virginia

How to use this book

Each lesson matches the interactive Sacred Geography presentation segment by segment. Lines set in shaded boxes are suggested teacher talk; say them in your own words. Answer keys for every game and quiz are included, and quiz letters match both the screen and the printed student handouts.

The five-step routine

STEP	MINUTES	WHAT HAPPENS
Wonder	3	An open question; think, pair, share.
Learn	7–10	Four short ideas and key terms.
Map	3	Locate the day's sites (when the lesson has sites).
Explore	9	A whole-class game, a group task and a discussion question.
Quiz	5	Four or five multiple-choice questions with explanations.
Reflect	3	A written reflection in the student passport and an exit ticket.

Approach

The course is academic and non-devotional: students learn *about* Hindu traditions and are never asked to practice or affirm beliefs. Use phrasing such as "many Hindus believe" and "this story is important to devotees." Distinguish emic (insider) descriptions from etic (outsider) analysis. Students with personal connections may share if they choose, but no student speaks for all Hindus.

Assessment

COMPONENT	ASSIGNED	DUE
Site Profile 1: one site, three sources of different types	Dec 13 (Class 8)	Jan 10
Site Profile 2: one site with a systems diagram or analysis	Feb 21 (Class 14)	Apr 18
Capstone exhibit: thesis, map, timeline, analysis, present-day issue, three sources	May 9 (Class 24)	May 16, Annual Day
Passport reflections and participation	Every class	Ongoing

Curriculum Classes 9–10 and 22–23 are combined so that all 25 classes fit 22 class Sundays plus Annual Day.

Year at a glance

DATE	CLASS	TOPIC	UNIT
Oct 4	1	What Makes a Place Sacred?	1
Oct 11	2	Inside a Hindu Temple	1
Oct 18	3	Architecture Across Regions	1
Oct 25	4	The Pilgrim's Journey	1
Nov 1	*No class — Daylight Saving ends*		
Nov 7	*Grand Diwali Party (Saturday)*		
Nov 8	*No class — day after Diwali party*		
Nov 15	5	Reading Sources and Sacred Narratives	1
Nov 22	6	Varanasi and Kashi Vishwanath	2
Nov 29	*No class — Thanksgiving weekend*		
Dec 6	7	Prayagraj, Haridwar and the Kumbh Mela	2
Dec 13	8	Ayodhya, Mathura and Vrindavan	2
Dec 20	*Winter break — Dec 20 to Jan 3*		
Jan 10	9–10	Himalayan Sacred Landscapes	2
Jan 17	*No class — MLK weekend*		
Jan 24	11	The All-India Char Dham	3
Jan 31	12	Shiva and the Jyotirlinga Network	3
Feb 7	13	Shakti Peethas and Goddess Traditions	3
Feb 14	*No class — Presidents Day weekend*		
Feb 21	14	Vishnu and Krishna Pilgrimage Centers	3
Feb 28	15	Festivals that Move the Deity	3
Mar 7	16	Madurai Meenakshi and the Temple-City	4
Mar 14	17	Thanjavur, Chidambaram and Temple Arts	4
Mar 21	*Spring break — Mar 21 and 28*		
Apr 4	18	Rameswaram and the Sea	4
Apr 11	19	Hampi, Ellora, Khajuraho and Konark	4
Apr 18	20	Beyond India: Bali, Cambodia and the Global Hindu World	4
Apr 25	21	Temple Communities, Food and Service	5

May 2	22–23	Etiquette, Heritage and Sustainable Pilgrimage	5
May 9	24	Capstone Workshop	5
May 16	25	Exhibition, Reflection and Synthesis **Annual Day**	5
May 30	*No class — Memorial Day weekend*		

Units: 1 — Foundations: Sacred Place, Temple and Pilgrimage · 2 — Sacred Rivers, Cities and Northern Routes · 3 — Pan-Indian Circuits and Major Traditions · 4 — Southern and Western Temple Landscapes · 5 — Living Sacred Places: Community, Ethics, Stewardship.

What Makes a Place Sacred?

OBJECTIVES — STUDENTS CAN:

1. Define tirtha and explain how its meaning grew from a river crossing to a spiritual one.
2. Analyze a sacred site through narrative, practice and community.
3. Distinguish an emic (insider) statement from an etic (outsider) one.
4. Write a thesis sentence about what makes a place sacred, supported by evidence.

TIMING

Wonder	3 min	0:00–0:03
Learn	7 min	0:03–0:10
Map	3 min	0:10–0:13
Explore	9 min	0:13–0:22
Quiz	5 min	0:22–0:27
Reflect	3 min	0:27–0:30

KEY TERMS

tirtha	TEER-tha	ford; a sacred crossing place
kshetra	KSHAY-tra	a sacred field or region
emic / etic	EE-mik / ET-ik	insider description / outsider analysis

Materials: presentation (Class 1), student handout for Class 1, passports or notebooks, South Asia map.

Wonder 3 min

"Why do some places become sacred while others do not, and who decides?"

> Welcome to Sacred Geography. This year we will travel, on maps and through stories, to temples, rivers, mountains and cities that matter deeply to Hindu communities. We will study them the way a historian or anthropologist would: with curiosity, evidence and respect. Here is our first question: why do some places become sacred while others do not, and who decides? Think of a place that is sacred to any community: a temple, a church, a mountain, a memorial, even a stadium for some fans. Is its sacredness in the land itself, in the stories people tell about it, or in the people who keep coming back?

Teacher move: Write answers on the board in three unlabeled columns: land or nature, stories, people or practices. If a student says "because it's beautiful," ask: "Many places are beautiful. What makes this one different?" You will name the columns in Learn.

Learn 7 min

1. Tirtha: the crossing

> The Sanskrit word tirtha first meant a ford: a shallow place where you can safely cross a river. Long ago, rivers were dangerous, and a safe crossing could mean life or death. Over time the word took on a second meaning. In texts like the Mahabharata, which describes journeys to many tirthas, a sacred place is a spot where it is easier to "cross over" from ordinary life toward the divine. One word holds both geography and spiritual meaning.

2. A sacred geography

> In Hindu traditions, meaning is mapped onto the land itself. Many Hindus honor rivers as goddesses: the Ganga as Ganga Ma, and the Yamuna too. Mountains are described as homes of the divine; many traditions see Mount Kailash as the abode of Shiva. Whole cities, like Kashi, also called Varanasi, are treated as sacred centers. The scholar Diana Eck, in India: A Sacred Geography (2012), argues that pilgrimage routes knit the subcontinent into one sacred landscape long before modern borders.

3. Three lenses

> Point to the three columns on the board and name them. Scholars often study a sacred place through three lenses. Narrative: the stories that mark a site, such as the Ganga descending from heaven. Practice: what people do there, such as bathing, darshan, or walking around a mountain. Community: the people who sustain it, such as priests, pilgrims, boatmen and families who return for generations. Most sacred places need all three.

4. Insider and outsider

> When we study religion, we separate two kinds of statements. An emic statement describes meaning from inside a tradition: “For devotees, bathing in the Ganga purifies.” An etic statement analyzes from outside: “Pilgrimage brings income to the city.” Both are useful; our job is to be clear which one we are making. That is why we say “many Hindus believe” instead of “Hindus believe” or “it is true that.” Traditions differ among families, regions and communities.

Check for understanding: *Why might a river crossing be a good image for a spiritual journey?*

Map 3 min

Tap each numbered site on the screen as you speak.

#	SITE	WHERE	WHAT TO SAY
1	**Varanasi (Kashi)**	Uttar Pradesh	Ancient city on the Ganga with stone ghats and the Kashi Vishwanath temple of Shiva.
2	**Haridwar**	Uttarakhand	Where the Ganga leaves the mountains for the plains. Evening aarti at Har ki Pauri ghat.
3	**Gangotri**	Uttarakhand	Temple of Goddess Ganga, near the glacier where the river begins.
4	**Mount Kailash**	Tibet (China)	Mountain linked with Shiva. Pilgrims walk around it (about 52 km) instead of climbing it.

Explore 9 min

Step 1 · Whole class (2–3 min)

Place Varanasi, Haridwar, Gangotri and Mount Kailash on the map. Note how all four connect to the Ganga or the Himalayas.

ANSWER KEY

Sort game: Narrative, practice or community?

GROUP	CARDS THAT BELONG
Narrative	Story of the Ganga descending from heaven · Kailash described as Shiva's abode · King Bhagiratha's penance brings the river to earth
Practice	Ritual bath at Har ki Pauri, Haridwar · Walking the circuit around Kailash · Evening Ganga aarti
Community	Haridwar priests keeping family genealogy registers · Boatmen families serving pilgrims for generations

Map game: Find it on the map

Students tap each named site on the map: Varanasi (Kashi), Haridwar, Gangotri, Mount Kailash.

Step 2 · Task (4–5 min)

> You have three minutes. Your group explains why its site is sacred using all three lenses: one story, one practice, one community. Then choose a speaker to make a 60-second case to the class.

Prompts for groups that get stuck:

- Varanasi: the belief that dying in Kashi brings liberation; bathing and aarti on the ghats; boatmen, priests and weavers.
- Haridwar: the Ganga entering the plains; the bath and aarti at Har ki Pauri; genealogy-keeping priests.
- Gangotri: the descent of the Ganga story; pilgrimage open only in summer; local priests and seasonal pilgrims.
- Kailash: abode of Shiva; walking the circuit; pilgrims from four traditions and border permits.

Step 3 · Discussion (2 min)

"Can a place lose its sacredness? Consider pollution of the Ganga, mass tourism or rapid urban growth."

Look for: Pollution changes practice (people hesitate to bathe), but narrative may keep the place sacred. Accept disagreement; the goal is reasoning, not one answer.

Quiz 5 min

Students answer individually (fingers 1–4 or on the handout) before you reveal.

#	QUESTION	ANSWER	WHY
1	What did the word tirtha originally mean?	**D** A ford or river crossing	The meaning grew from a physical crossing to a spiritual one.
2	Which statement is emic (an insider description)?	**A** "For devotees, bathing at the Sangam washes away sins."	Emic statements report meaning from inside the tradition.
3	At Haridwar, many priestly families are known for keeping…	**A** Genealogy registers of pilgrim families	Families can trace ancestors' visits across generations.
4	Mount Kailash is sacred to which traditions?	**C** Hindu, Buddhist, Jain and Bon	Shared sacred landscapes are a theme of this course.
5	Which phrasing best fits academic writing?	**A** "Many Hindus regard the Ganga as a goddess."	It is accurate, specific and avoids generalizing.

Reflect 3 min

Passport prompt: Write a thesis sentence: "A place becomes sacred when…" Support it with evidence from one of today's sites.

Model answer: *A place becomes sacred when a story, a repeated practice and a community all meet there, as at Haridwar, where the Ganga's descent story, the daily aarti and generations of priestly families keep it alive.*

Exit ticket: one word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

Next class: Sunday, October 11, 2026 — Class 2: Inside a Hindu Temple.

Teacher background

In the story of the Ganga's descent, King Bhagiratha performs long penance so the heavenly Ganga will come to earth to free his ancestors. Shiva catches the river in his hair to soften her fall. Gangotri sits near the river's source; the main headstream is called the Bhagirathi after the king.

Questions students may ask

"Is the story true?"
Sacred stories and history answer different questions. We study what the story means to the people who tell it. In Class 5 we look at how historians use different sources.

"Do all Hindus go on pilgrimage?"
No. Practices vary by family, region and community. Many do; many don't.

"Why is the Ganga polluted if it's sacred?"
Sacredness and pollution can exist together. India runs a national clean-up program, Namami Gange; we return to this in May.

"Who owns Kailash?"
It is in Tibet, governed by China. Pilgrims from India need permits, so politics shapes the journey.

Quick notes

- Welcome to Sacred Geography. Explain the five-part routine and the academic, non-devotional approach: we study traditions, not practice them.
- Push past 'it's beautiful'. Ask who decides and how sacredness is maintained.
- Spend time on emic and etic; it frames every class this year.
- Note that Kailash is in Tibet (China): sacred geography crosses modern borders.
- Run the sort as a warm-up, then groups prepare 60-second cases.
- Let students answer individually, then discuss question 2.
- Collect thesis sentences; revisit them at the final class in May.

Inside a Hindu Temple

OBJECTIVES — STUDENTS CAN:

1. Identify the main spaces of a Hindu temple and the path between them.
2. Explain darshan, puja, murti and prasad accurately, using emic framing.
3. Analyze how architecture shapes movement, light and attention.
4. Compare a historic temple plan with a diaspora temple in the US.

TIMING

Wonder	3 min	0:00–0:03
Learn	10 min	0:03–0:13
Explore	9 min	0:13–0:22
Quiz	5 min	0:22–0:27
Reflect	3 min	0:27–0:30

KEY TERMS

garbhagriha	GAR-bha-gri-ha	inner shrine room
pradakshina	pra-DUK-shi-na	clockwise circling
Vastu Shastra	VAAS-too SHAAS-tra	texts on sacred design
murti	MOOR-ti	sacred image

Materials: presentation (Class 2), student handout for Class 2, passports or notebooks.

Wonder 3 min

"How does a building tell you how to move, where to look and how to feel?"

> How does a building tell you how to move, where to look and how to feel? Think of four buildings: a temple, a cathedral, a sports stadium and a shopping mall. In each one, where does the building want you to go? Where does it want you to look? Talk with a partner for one minute and pick one design feature that controls people's behavior.

Teacher move: Collect examples such as aisles, stairs, lighting, ticket gates and stages. Point out that every building "choreographs" its visitors. Today we read a temple the same way.

Learn 10 min

1. A path toward the center

> Many Hindu temples lead visitors along a path. You enter through a gateway, cross a courtyard, pass through one or more halls, and arrive at a small, often dim inner shrine called the garbhagriha, the "womb chamber." The spaces become more sacred and more enclosed as you move inward. Scholars describe this as a journey from the outer world toward a sacred center, built into stone.

2. Tower and shrine

Above the inner shrine rises a tower. In northern styles it is called a shikhara, a curved peak; in southern styles a vimana, a stepped pyramid. The tower marks the sacred center from far away, the way a steeple marks a church. Traditional manuals called the Vastu Shastras and Shilpa Shastras set out rules for proportions, orientation and images. Many temples face east, toward the rising sun.

3. Darshan

Darshan means seeing. For many Hindus, a temple visit centers on darshan: seeing the deity and being seen in return. The scholar Diana Eck describes this as a two-way exchange of sight. That is why the eyes of a murti, the sacred image, matter so much, and why devotees may wait in long lines for even a moment of darshan.

4. Puja and prasad

Puja is worship with offerings: light from lamps, flowers, incense, water and food. Food offered to the deity and then shared with devotees is called prasad. Many visitors also walk clockwise around the shrine, keeping it on their right, which is called pradakshina. Practices differ from temple to temple and family to family, so we describe them, not prescribe them.

Check for understanding: *Why might the inner shrine be small and dim rather than large and bright?*

Explore 9 min

Step 1 · Whole class (2–3 min)

Use the temple diagram to trace a visitor's path from gateway to shrine.

ANSWER KEY

Matching game: Match the terms

TERM	MATCH
darshan	seeing and being seen by the deity
puja	worship with offerings
murti	sacred image of a deity
prasad	food offered and returned as blessing
mandapa	pillared hall for gathering
garbhagriha	inner shrine room
pradakshina	clockwise circling of the shrine

Ordering game: Order the spaces, outer to inner

1. Gateway
2. Outer courtyard
3. Mandapa (hall)
4. Antarala (vestibule)
5. Garbhagriha (inner shrine)

Step 2 · Task (4–5 min)

In pairs, compare the two floor plans on your sheet: one North Indian temple and one South Indian temple. Write three observations about how space, light and movement shape a visit. Use at least two of today's terms.

Prompts for groups that get stuck:

- Where does the visitor enter, and how many thresholds do they cross?
- Where is the light brightest and darkest?
- Where would a crowd gather, and where would it be quiet?
- How does the southern plan's gateway tower change the approach?

Step 3 · Discussion (2 min)

"Diaspora temples in the US often combine many deities, classrooms and kitchens under one roof. What changes when a temple is built far from its home region?"

Look for: Diaspora temples often combine several deities, a hall for events, classrooms and a kitchen under one roof, because they serve a whole community far from home. Students should notice both continuity (inner shrine, darshan) and change (multi-purpose spaces, parking, English signs).

Quiz 5 min

Students answer individually (fingers 1–4 or on the handout) before you reveal.

#	QUESTION	ANSWER	WHY
1	Why is the garbhagriha usually small and dim?	**A** It concentrates attention on the murti, the sacred center	Space and light focus the visit inward.
2	Darshan is best described as…	**D** A two-way exchange of sight between devotee and deity	This is why the murti's eyes are so significant.
3	Which texts give rules for temple proportions and plans?	**D** Vastu and Shilpa Shastras	They are treatises on architecture and image-making.
4	Pradakshina is performed…	**D** Clockwise, keeping the shrine on the right	Many temples have a circumambulation path.

Reflect 3 min

Passport prompt: Describe how one feature of temple design (path, light, tower or hall) shapes a visitor's experience. Use one specific term from today.

Model answer: *The dim, enclosed garbhagriha focuses a visitor's attention on the murti, so the moment of darshan feels concentrated and personal after the busy outer halls.*

Exit ticket: one word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

Next class: Sunday, October 18, 2026 — Class 3: Architecture Across Regions.

Teacher background

A typical plan runs: gateway (gopuram in the south), courtyard, mandapa (pillared hall), antarala (vestibule), garbhagriha. The circumambulation path may run inside the walls or around the shrine. Many US temples, such as those in the Washington, D.C. area, were built from the 1970s onward and adapt these elements for community use.

Questions students may ask

"Can non-Hindus enter temples?"

Most temples welcome visitors, especially in the US. Some temples in India restrict entry to the inner shrine or to Hindus only. Always check the temple's own rules.

"Do Hindus worship the statue?"

For many devotees the murti is a form in which the deity is present, not just a statue. We describe that belief respectfully and note that views vary.

"Why take off shoes?"

As a sign of respect and to keep the sacred space clean. It is also common in many homes.

Quick notes

- If possible, show plans of a local Virginia temple alongside a historic one.
- Stress that practices vary; describe, don't prescribe.
- After the order game, students compare plans.
- Next week: regional temple styles.

Architecture Across Regions

OBJECTIVES — STUDENTS CAN:

1. Describe the Nagara, Dravida, Vesara, Kalinga and rock-cut temple forms.
2. Use visual evidence to identify a temple's style.
3. Explain how rulers, materials and artisans shaped regional styles.
4. Evaluate the strengths and limits of style labels.

TIMING

Wonder	3 min	0:00–0:03
Learn	7 min	0:03–0:10
Map	3 min	0:10–0:13
Explore	9 min	0:13–0:22
Quiz	5 min	0:22–0:27
Reflect	3 min	0:27–0:30

KEY TERMS

shikhara	SHIK-ha-ra	curved northern tower
vimana	vi-MAA-na	stepped southern tower
gopuram	GO-pu-ram	gateway tower
Vesara	VAY-sa-ra	mixed Deccan style

Materials: presentation (Class 3), student handout for Class 3, passports or notebooks, South Asia map.

Wonder 3 min

"Why would two kingdoms in the same religious tradition build temples that look so different?"

> Why would two kingdoms in the same religious tradition build temples that look completely different? Think about materials, climate, rulers, artisans and competition between kingdoms. Give me one reason.

Teacher move: Take three or four reasons. Steer students to see that architecture is shaped by local stone, engineering skill, royal patronage and the desire to impress rivals.

Learn 7 min

1. Nagara (north)

> In northern India, the Nagara style crowns the shrine with a shikhara, a curving tower that rises like a mountain peak. Smaller tower forms often cluster around the main one, so the whole temple looks like a mountain range. The Kandariya Mahadeva temple at Khajuraho, built around 1030 under the Chandela dynasty, is a classic example.

2. Dravida (south)

> In the south, the Dravida style uses a vimana: a stepped, pyramid-shaped tower. The Brihadisvara temple at Thanjavur, completed around 1010 by the Chola king Rajaraja I, has a granite vimana about 66 meters tall. In later centuries, southern builders shifted their energy to huge gateway towers called gopurams, which often grew taller than the shrine itself.

3. Vesara and Kalinga

> Some regions blended these ideas. In the Deccan, the Vesara style mixes northern and southern features. At Pattadakal in Karnataka, built in the 7th and 8th centuries under the Chalukyas, northern and southern temples stand side by side, like an architectural experiment. In Odisha, the Kalinga style produced the Lingaraja temple in Bhubaneswar, with its tall, ribbed tower.

4. Rock-cut

> Finally, some temples were carved rather than built. The Kailasa temple at Ellora, made in the 8th century under the Rashtrakutas, was cut downward from a single basalt cliff. Workers could only remove stone, never add it back, so the design had to be planned perfectly from the start. It is one of the largest monolithic structures in the world.

Check for understanding: *Why might southern kings later choose to make gateways taller than the shrine?*

Map 3 min

Tap each numbered site on the screen as you speak.

#	SITE	WHERE	WHAT TO SAY
1	**Khajuraho**	Madhya Pradesh	Chandela-era temples (about 950–1050 CE) with tall, curved Nagara towers.
2	**Thanjavur**	Tamil Nadu	Brihadisvara temple, completed around 1010 CE by the Chola king Rajaraja I.
3	**Pattadakal**	Karnataka	Northern (Nagara) and southern (Dravida) temple styles built side by side.
4	**Bhubaneswar**	Odisha	City of temples. The Lingaraja temple shows the Kalinga style.
5	**Ellora**	Maharashtra	Hindu, Buddhist and Jain caves. The Kailasa temple was carved from one rock.

Explore 9 min

Step 1 · Whole class (2–3 min)

Sort the style clues, then compare the three tower silhouettes.

ANSWER KEY

Sort game: Which style?

GROUP	CARDS THAT BELONG
Nagara	Curvilinear shikhara · Kandariya Mahadeva, Khajuraho · Lingaraja, Bhubaneswar (Kalinga variant)
Dravida	Stepped pyramidal vimana · Brihadisvara, Thanjavur · Monumental gateway gopurams
Rock-cut	Kailasa temple, Ellora · Shaped by removing stone only

Map game: Find it on the map

Students tap each named site on the map: Khajuraho, Thanjavur, Pattadakal, Bhubaneswar, Ellora.

Step 2 · Task (4–5 min)

> Choose one temple from the slide. Argue whether it fits neatly into one style label or blends several. Give two visual details as evidence. You have four minutes; be ready to defend your choice.

Prompts for groups that get stuck:

- Look at the tower's outline: curved or stepped?
- Look for gateway towers.
- Is the temple built from blocks or carved from rock?
- Do you see features from more than one style?

Step 3 · Discussion (2 min)

"Why might a later southern dynasty make gateways taller than the central shrine? What does that say about public display and power?"

Look for: Tall gopurams made temples visible from across the city and displayed royal and community wealth to the public, even to people who never entered the inner shrine. Students should connect architecture to power and public display.

Quiz 5 min

Students answer individually (fingers 1–4 or on the handout) before you reveal.

#	QUESTION	ANSWER	WHY
1	Which feature defines the Nagara style?	**B** A curvilinear shikhara over the shrine	Khajuraho is a classic example.
2	Why is Pattadakal important to architectural history?	**B** Northern and southern styles stand side by side	It shows experimentation under the Chalukyas.
3	What made the Kailasa temple an engineering feat?	**B** It was carved downward from one cliff	Mistakes could not be undone.
4	What is the strongest critique of style labels?	**D** Real temples often blend features across categories	Typologies simplify a messy reality.

Reflect 3 min

Passport prompt: In two sentences, explain one strength and one limitation of classifying temples by style.

Model answer: *Style labels help us compare temples quickly, but they simplify reality, because many temples, like those at Pattadakal, mix northern and southern features.*

Exit ticket: one word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

Next class: Sunday, October 25, 2026 — Class 4: The Pilgrim's Journey.

Teacher background

The terms Nagara, Dravida and Vesara appear in traditional texts but were systematized by modern art historians. Pattadakal is a UNESCO World Heritage Site (1987); so are Khajuraho, Ellora and the Great Living Chola Temples, including Thanjavur.

Questions students may ask

"Which style is the 'best'?"

None. Each answers local needs, materials and ideas. Historians compare them, not rank them.

"How did they carve Ellora without machines?"

With iron chisels and hammers, working from the top down over many years, probably with large teams of skilled artisans.

Quick notes

- Show photos of each example if available.
- Groups pick a temple and argue fit vs. blend.
- Next week: pilgrimage as a journey.

The Pilgrim's Journey

OBJECTIVES — STUDENTS CAN:

1. Explain common motives for Hindu pilgrimage.
2. Apply Victor Turner's ideas of liminality and communitas.
3. Plan a pilgrimage that accounts for cost, access and environmental impact.
4. Evaluate how modern transport changes pilgrimage.

TIMING

Wonder	3 min	0:00–0:03
Learn	10 min	0:03–0:13
Explore	9 min	0:13–0:22
Quiz	5 min	0:22–0:27
Reflect	3 min	0:27–0:30

KEY TERMS

yatra	YAA-tra	journey, pilgrimage
liminality	lim-i-NAL-i-tee	in-between state
communitas	kom-YOO-ni-tas	shared sense of equality
vrata	VRUH-ta	vow

Materials: presentation (Class 4), student handout for Class 4, passports or notebooks.

Wonder 3 min

"Is a pilgrimage mainly about arriving, or about the journey itself?"

> Is a pilgrimage mainly about arriving, or about the journey itself? Think about any long journey you've made with a purpose: a family trip to India, a college visit, a camping trip. What did the journey itself do to you?

Teacher move: Contrast answers about destination with answers about the road. Keep both sides on the board; the lesson will show that many pilgrims value the journey itself.

Learn 10 min

1. Yatra

> A tirtha yatra is a journey to a sacred place. People go for many reasons: devotion, gratitude for a recovery or a new baby, fulfilling a vow called a vrata, prayers for family, performing rites for ancestors, learning, or simply being with community. One family may hold several of these motives at once.

2. Liminality

> The anthropologist Victor Turner studied pilgrims around the world. He said pilgrims enter a liminal state, an in-between time when they leave their ordinary roles behind. On the road, a banker and a farmer may wear the same simple clothes, eat the same food and sleep in the same shelter. Turner called this shared sense of equality communitas.

3. The journey matters

> For many pilgrims the hardships of the road are part of the meaning. Walking long distances, singing bhajans together, fasting, and sharing meals with strangers are seen as acts of devotion in themselves. The Pandharpur Wari, which we study in February, is a walk of about three weeks where the journey is the heart of the pilgrimage.

4. Changing pilgrimage

> Pilgrimage has changed enormously. Railways in the 19th century, then roads, buses, flights and even helicopters to mountain shrines, have opened sacred places to millions. Online booking and darshan tickets are common. This brings access to elders and people with disabilities, but also crowding, cost and environmental pressure.

Check for understanding: *Can you think of a non-religious journey that creates communitas, like a team trip or a march?*

Explore 9 min

Step 1 · Whole class (2–3 min)

Arrange the journey stages and discuss what changes for a pilgrim at each stage.

ANSWER KEY

Ordering game: Stages of a pilgrimage

1. Prepare (vow, packing, farewells)
2. Travel
3. Arrive
4. Darshan and rituals
5. Share food and prasad
6. Return home
7. Remember and retell

Sort game: Turner's ideas or not?

GROUP	CARDS THAT BELONG
Fits liminality / communitas	Pilgrims wear simple, similar clothing · Strangers share meals on the road · Social rank matters less during the journey
Doesn't fit	VIP darshan lines for paying visitors · Separate luxury tours from other pilgrims

Step 2 · Task (4–5 min)

> In groups of three, plan a family pilgrimage to any site we've mentioned. Decide on season, route, transport and budget, and how you will include an elderly grandparent. Then name one trade-off you had to make.

Prompts for groups that get stuck:

- Cheaper often means slower; faster often means more emissions.
- Mountain sites are only open in summer.
- Accessibility: steps, altitude, crowds.
- Would walking part of the way add meaning?

Step 3 · Discussion (2 min)

"Does a helicopter ride to a mountain shrine change the meaning of pilgrimage? Make the case for both sides."

Look for: Arguments for: helicopters let elders and disabled pilgrims reach shrines. Arguments against: they skip the journey's meaning, add noise and emissions, and strain fragile valleys. Strong answers acknowledge both and suggest a balance.

Quiz 5 min

Students answer individually (fingers 1–4 or on the handout) before you reveal.

#	QUESTION	ANSWER	WHY
1	Turner used "communitas" to describe...	**B** A shared sense of equality among pilgrims	Pilgrims step outside ordinary social roles.
2	Which is a liminal experience?	**A** Being between ordinary life and the destination	Liminal means in-between.
3	Which is a common motive for pilgrimage?	**B** Fulfilling a vow	Vows (vratas) often motivate journeys.
4	Which development most changed access to pilgrimage sites?	**D** Modern transport such as railways and roads	Access expanded to millions.

Reflect 3 min

Passport prompt: Answer with an example: how can a journey change a person, and does ease of travel change that?

Model answer: *A journey can change a person because it removes them from everyday roles, as Turner describes, but faster travel may shorten that in-between time and weaken its effect.*

Exit ticket: one word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

Next class: Sunday, November 15, 2026 — Class 5: Reading Sources and Sacred Narratives.

Teacher background

Turner's ideas (from the 1960s–70s) are influential but debated. Critics note that pilgrimages often reinforce social differences, such as VIP darshan lines. Use the model as a lens, not a rule.

Questions students may ask

"Do people still walk?"

Yes. Many pilgrimages, like the Wari, the Kanwar Yatra and the Sabarimala climb, include walking.

"Is a helicopter pilgrimage less valid?"

Communities disagree. Many say intention matters more than method.

Quick notes

- Diwali party is Sat Nov 7. No class Nov 1 or Nov 8.
- Introduce Turner as one scholar's model, open to critique.
- Next class Nov 15: reading sources.

Reading Sources and Sacred Narratives

OBJECTIVES — STUDENTS CAN:

1. Classify sources as narrative, object, place, image or written record.
2. Apply source questions: who, when, for whom, why, and limits.
3. Explain how historians use sacred narratives as evidence of belief.
4. Evaluate insider and outsider accounts critically.

TIMING

Wonder	3 min	0:00–0:03
Learn	10 min	0:03–0:13
Explore	9 min	0:13–0:22
Quiz	5 min	0:22–0:27
Reflect	3 min	0:27–0:30

KEY TERMS

sthala purana	STHUL-a poo-RAA-na	a temple's local origin story
inscription	in-SKRIP-shun	text carved on stone or copper
provenance	PROV-e-nunce	where a source comes from

Materials: presentation (Class 5), student handout for Class 5, passports or notebooks.

Wonder 3 min

"Can a story be true in a different way from a history book?"

> Can a story be true in a different way from a history book? Think about a family story your grandparents tell. It may not be exact in every detail, but is it still 'true' in some way? What kind of truth?

Teacher move: Draw out two kinds of truth: factual accuracy and meaningful truth (values, identity, memory). Both matter; historians just ask different questions of each.

Learn 10 min

1. Kinds of sources

> Historians use many kinds of sources. Narratives include epics like the Ramayana, the Puranas, and a temple's sthala purana, its local origin story. Objects include bronzes, lamps and coins. Places include ghats and temple ruins. Images include paintings and photographs. Written records include stone and copper-plate inscriptions, travel accounts and government surveys.

2. Source questions

> For every source, ask five questions. Who made it? When? For whom? Why? And what can it not tell us? A copper-plate land grant tells us who donated land to a temple and when, but not what ordinary visitors felt. A painting shows how an artist imagined a scene, not necessarily how it looked.

3. Sacred narratives

> Sacred narratives carry meaning, values and memory for devotees. Historians treat them as evidence of what communities believed and valued at different times, not as proof that events happened exactly as described. Archaeology, inscriptions and texts answer different questions. Keeping these apart lets us respect the story and study history honestly.

4. Outside observers

> Outsiders also wrote about Indian religion. The Chinese monk Xuanzang traveled in the 7th century; the Persian scholar Al-Biruni wrote about India in the 11th century; British officials wrote surveys in the 19th. Their accounts are valuable, but shaped by their own languages, beliefs and goals. Every source has a perspective.

Check for understanding: *What can a photograph of a festival not tell us?*

Explore 9 min

Step 1 · Whole class (2–3 min)

Sort the source cards by type, then rank two of them by how useful they are for a specific question.

ANSWER KEY

Sort game: Source type

GROUP	CARDS THAT BELONG
Narrative	A temple's sthala purana · Ramayana episode
Object	Bronze Nataraja
Place	Ghats of Varanasi
Image	19th-century photograph of a festival · Mughal-era miniature painting
Written record	Copper-plate land grant · Al-Biruni's account of India

Step 2 · Task (4–5 min)

> Your question is: "Why did pilgrims visit this temple in the 1100s?" Rank three sources from most to least useful: the temple's sthala purana, a royal inscription from 1120, and a modern travel blog. Justify each ranking with the source questions.

Prompts for groups that get stuck:

- Which source is closest in time to the 1100s?
- Which tells us what people believed?
- Which was written to promote something?
- Could the blog still be useful for a different question?

Step 3 · Discussion (2 min)

"Can an outsider's account ever be more accurate than an insider's? When might it be less accurate?"

Look for: Outsiders may notice things insiders take for granted and may record details locals didn't write down. But they can misunderstand meanings or carry biases. Insiders understand meaning better but may idealize. Strong answers use both.

Quiz 5 min

Students answer individually (fingers 1–4 or on the handout) before you reveal.

#	QUESTION	ANSWER	WHY
1	A copper-plate land grant to a temple is best used to learn...	**A** Who funded the temple and what they gave	Grants record donors, gifts and dates.
2	Historians treat sacred narratives as evidence of...	**C** What communities believed and valued	They answer questions about belief and memory.
3	Why read colonial surveys critically?	**A** Their authors' assumptions shaped what they recorded	Every source has a perspective.
4	What is a sthala purana?	**B** A temple's local origin story	Many temples have one.

Reflect 3 min

Passport prompt: Choose one source type and explain one question it can answer well and one it cannot.

Model answer: *A royal inscription can show who funded a temple and when, but it cannot tell us what ordinary pilgrims experienced or believed.*

Exit ticket: one word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

Next class: Sunday, November 22, 2026 — Class 6: Varanasi and Kashi Vishwanath.

Teacher background

Many South Indian temples carry thousands of inscriptions in Tamil, Kannada, Telugu and Sanskrit; they are among the richest sources for medieval social history. Copper-plate grants were legal documents recording land gifts.

Questions students may ask

"So are the epics false?"

That is not the question historians ask. They ask what the epics meant to people and how they shaped practice and places.

"Were colonial accounts always wrong?"

No. Some are very valuable, but they must be read critically, like any source.

Quick notes

- Welcome back after Diwali. Optional, brief sharing.
- Model the source questions on one card together.
- Next: Varanasi.

Varanasi and Kashi Vishwanath

OBJECTIVES — STUDENTS CAN:

1. Locate Varanasi and describe its ghats and major temple.
2. Explain multiple meanings of one city: worship, learning, trade, life and death.
3. Analyze the Kashi Vishwanath Corridor as a heritage debate.
4. Write a balanced argument with a counterargument.

TIMING

Wonder	3 min	0:00–0:03
Learn	7 min	0:03–0:10
Map	3 min	0:10–0:13
Explore	9 min	0:13–0:22
Quiz	5 min	0:22–0:27
Reflect	3 min	0:27–0:30

KEY TERMS

ghat	GAAT	steps to a river
moksha	MOKE-sha	liberation
aarti	AAR-tee	worship with lamps

Materials: presentation (Class 6), student handout for Class 6, passports or notebooks, South Asia map.

Wonder 3 min

“How can a city be a home, a marketplace, a university town and a sacred center at once?”

> How can one city be a home, a marketplace, a university town and a sacred center all at once? Imagine you are a boatman, a silk weaver, a university student and a pilgrim in the same city. Would you experience it the same way?

Teacher move: List each role on the board with what they would notice first. This sets up the idea that a sacred city holds many overlapping meanings.

Learn 7 min

1. Kashi, Banaras, Varanasi

> Varanasi, also called Kashi and Banaras, sits on the western bank of the Ganga in Uttar Pradesh. It is often described as one of the oldest continuously inhabited cities in the world. The name Kashi is linked to a Sanskrit word for shining, so it is called the City of Light.

2. Ghats and the river

> More than 80 ghats, stone steps leading down to the river, line its waterfront. People bathe and pray here at dawn, wash laundry, practice wrestling and yoga, play music and cricket, and sail boats. At Manikarnika and Harishchandra ghats, cremations take place day and night, part of the city’s link with the end of life.

3. Kashi Vishwanath

> The Kashi Vishwanath temple is dedicated to Shiva as Vishwanath, Lord of the Universe, and is one of the twelve Jyotirlingas. It was destroyed and rebuilt several times. Queen Ahilyabai Holkar of Indore built the present temple in 1780. In 2021, the Kashi Vishwanath Corridor opened, creating a wide passage from the temple to the river.

4. Many meanings

> Many Hindus believe that dying in Kashi brings moksha, liberation from the cycle of rebirth, so some elderly people move to the city to spend their last days. Varanasi is also famous for Banarasi silk saris, Hindustani classical music, and Banaras Hindu University, founded in 1916.

Check for understanding: *Why do you think the evening Ganga aarti attracts both devotees and tourists?*

Map 3 min

Tap each numbered site on the screen as you speak.

#	SITE	WHERE	WHAT TO SAY
1	**Varanasi (Kashi)**	Uttar Pradesh	Ancient city on the Ganga with stone ghats and the Kashi Vishwanath temple of Shiva.

Explore 9 min

Step 1 · Whole class (2–3 min)

Follow a photo journey from the river to the temple lanes.

ANSWER KEY

Sort game: One city, many meanings

GROUP	CARDS THAT BELONG
Worship	Evening Ganga aarti · Kashi Vishwanath
Learning & arts	Banaras Hindu University · Hindustani music gharanas
Work & trade	Banarasi silk looms · Boatmen ferrying visitors
Life & death	Cremation at Manikarnika ghat · Hospices for the dying

Ordering game: From river to temple

1. Boat on the Ganga at dawn
2. Climb the ghat steps
3. Walk the narrow lanes
4. Pass security and leave shoes
5. Darshan at Kashi Vishwanath

Step 2 · Task (4–5 min)

> In pairs, annotate the city map. Mark religious, residential and commercial spaces in three colors. Then find one place where they overlap and explain whether that overlap creates tension or harmony.

Prompts for groups that get stuck:

- The ghats serve worship, work and play at once.
- Lanes around the temple are full of shops.

- Where do residents live, and how do pilgrims affect them?
- Who benefits from tourism and who bears the costs?

Step 3 · Discussion (2 min)

"The 2021 corridor made the temple easier to reach but cleared old lanes and homes. How should cities balance access, heritage and residents' needs?"

Look for: The corridor improved access, safety and views, and drew huge numbers of visitors. Critics noted that old homes, small shrines and narrow lanes were cleared and residents relocated. Strong answers weigh access, heritage and residents' rights.

Quiz 5 min

Students answer individually (fingers 1–4 or on the handout) before you reveal.

#	QUESTION	ANSWER	WHY
1	Who built the present Kashi Vishwanath temple in 1780?	**B** Queen Ahilyabai Holkar	She sponsored temples across India.
2	Why do many Hindus hope to die in Kashi?	**B** It is believed to grant moksha (liberation)	An emic belief central to the city's identity.
3	What did the 2021 Kashi Vishwanath Corridor do?	**D** Linked the temple directly to the river ghats	It also raised heritage debates.
4	What does the name Kashi mean?	**A** City of light	Related to the Sanskrit for shining.

Reflect 3 min

Passport prompt: Argue in three sentences: should a sacred city prioritize pilgrims, residents or heritage? Acknowledge one counterargument.

Model answer: *A sacred city should prioritize its living community of residents and worshippers, because without them it becomes a museum; however, improving access for pilgrims also sustains the city's economy and sacred role.*

Exit ticket: one word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

Next class: Sunday, December 6, 2026 — Class 7: Prayagraj, Haridwar and the Kumbh Mela.

Teacher background

Historical accounts record that earlier Vishwanath temples were destroyed under various rulers, including in 1669 under Aurangzeb, when the Gyanvapi mosque was built on part of the site. This remains a subject of legal dispute today; mention it only factually if asked.

Questions students may ask

"Why are bodies cremated by the river?"

Many Hindus believe cremation at Kashi on the Ganga supports liberation. Families travel from far away for it.

"Is the river safe to bathe in?"

Water quality varies and has been a serious concern; clean-up programs are ongoing.

Quick notes

- Cremation is part of life in Varanasi; handle it factually and briefly.
- No class Nov 29. Next: Kumbh Mela, Dec 6.

Prayagraj, Haridwar and the Kumbh Mela

OBJECTIVES — STUDENTS CAN:

1. Explain the significance of river confluences and the Triveni Sangam.
2. Describe how and where the Kumbh Mela is held.
3. Analyze the planning systems a temporary mega-city requires.
4. Propose evidence-based ways to improve crowd safety.

TIMING

Wonder	3 min	0:00–0:03
Learn	7 min	0:03–0:10
Map	3 min	0:10–0:13
Explore	9 min	0:13–0:22
Quiz	5 min	0:22–0:27
Reflect	3 min	0:27–0:30

KEY TERMS

sangam	SUNG-um	confluence
amrita	UM-ri-ta	nectar of immortality
akhara	a-KHAA-ra	order of ascetics
snan	SNAAN	ritual bath

Materials: presentation (Class 7), student handout for Class 7, passports or notebooks, South Asia map.

Wonder 3 min

"How do you build, run and dismantle a temporary city for tens of millions?"

> How would you build, run and then take apart a city for tens of millions of people in a few weeks? List the systems a city needs in its first 24 hours. Go.

Teacher move: Collect: water, toilets, food, medical care, police, roads, bridges, electricity, lost-and-found, communications, waste. Keep the list for Explore.

Learn 7 min

1. Triveni Sangam

> At Prayagraj, formerly Allahabad, the Ganga and the Yamuna meet. Tradition says a third, unseen river, the Saraswati, joins them underground, so the place is called the Triveni Sangam, the meeting of three rivers. Many Hindus regard bathing at a confluence as especially purifying, and Prayagraj hosts a Magh Mela every winter.

2. Kumbh Mela

> The Kumbh Mela rotates among four river cities: Prayagraj, Haridwar, Ujjain and Nashik. Its timing is set by the positions of Jupiter, the sun and the moon. A story explains the four cities: when gods and demons churned the ocean for amrita, the nectar of immortality, drops fell at these four places. Each city hosts a Kumbh roughly every twelve years.

3. Scale and planning

> The scale is extraordinary. For the 2025 Maha Kumbh at Prayagraj, officials reported hundreds of millions of visits over about six weeks. On the dry riverbed, planners built a temporary city with tents, pontoon bridges, hospitals, police stations, water lines, toilets and lost-and-found centers, then removed most of it afterward.

4. Heritage and risk

> Ascetic orders called akharas lead processions to the river on the main bathing days, called shahi snan or amrit snan. In 2017 UNESCO added the Kumbh Mela to its list of Intangible Cultural Heritage. But extreme crowd density carries risk: deadly crowd crushes have occurred at several Kumbh Melas, including in 2013 and 2025.

Check for understanding: *Why might bathing days be the most dangerous days for crowds?*

Map 3 min

Tap each numbered site on the screen as you speak.

#	SITE	WHERE	WHAT TO SAY
1	**Prayagraj**	Uttar Pradesh	Triveni Sangam: where the Ganga and Yamuna meet with, in tradition, the unseen Saraswati.
2	**Haridwar**	Uttarakhand	Where the Ganga leaves the mountains for the plains. Evening aarti at Har ki Pauri ghat.
3	**Ujjain (Mahakaleshwar)**	Madhya Pradesh	Mahakaleshwar Jyotirlinga on the Shipra river. One of the four Kumbh Mela cities.
4	**Nashik**	Maharashtra	Kumbh Mela city on the Godavari. Trimbakeshwar Jyotirlinga is nearby.

Explore 9 min

Step 1 · Whole class (2–3 min)

Build a tabletop temporary city with cards for water, toilets, medical care, paths, food and waste.

ANSWER KEY

Matching game: Problem and system

TERM	MATCH
Peak bathing-day crowd surge	Timed entry and one-way routes
Waterborne disease risk	Clean water and sanitation
Lost children and elders	Lost-and-found centers
Crossing a wide river	Pontoon bridges
Tons of waste daily	Waste collection and segregation
Medical emergencies	Field hospitals

Map game: The four Kumbh cities

Students tap each named site on the map: Prayagraj, Haridwar, Ujjain (Mahakaleshwar), Nashik.

Step 2 · Task (4–5 min)

> You are the planning committee. You have money for only four of these six systems at full strength: water, sanitation, medical, bridges, waste, communications. Rank them and justify your top two. Then name one environmental and one safety trade-off of your plan.

Prompts for groups that get stuck:

- What spreads fastest in a crowd: disease or panic?
- Can one system reduce the need for another?
- Where do the river and the crowd meet?
- How do people find each other without phones?

Step 3 · Discussion (2 min)

"Who is responsible when a crowd disaster happens at a religious gathering: organizers, government, or no one? How can planning reduce risk?"

Look for: Responsibility is shared among organizers, police and government; good planning includes timed entry, one-way routes, real-time crowd monitoring, clear communication and enough exits. Avoid blaming pilgrims. Strong answers cite specific measures.

Quiz 5 min

Students answer individually (fingers 1–4 or on the handout) before you reveal.

#	QUESTION	ANSWER	WHY
1	What determines Kumbh Mela timing?	**A** Positions of Jupiter, the sun and the moon	Astrological reckoning sets the dates.
2	Which story explains the four Kumbh cities?	**D** Drops of amrita falling at four places	An emic explanation of the cycle.
3	When did UNESCO recognize the Kumbh Mela?	**C** 2017	As Intangible Cultural Heritage.
4	What are akharas?	**D** Orders of ascetics who lead the royal baths	Their processions are highlights of the Mela.

Reflect 3 min

Passport prompt: Name one joy and one danger of mass gatherings, and propose one evidence-based way to make them safer.

Model answer: *Mass gatherings create powerful shared experiences but can turn deadly when density gets too high; timed entry and one-way routes on peak bathing days would reduce surges.*

Exit ticket: one word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

Next class: Sunday, December 13, 2026 — Class 8: Ayodhya, Mathura and Vrindavan.

Teacher background

Crowd-safety research (e.g., by crowd scientists such as Keith Still) shows danger rises sharply above about five people per square meter. Verify any attendance figure with an official source before quoting it in class.

Questions students may ask

"Do people really bathe in winter?"

Yes. Many bathe at dawn in cold water as part of the devotion.

"Who are the naked ascetics?"

Some Naga sadhus renounce clothing as part of their vows. Describe them factually and briefly.

Quick notes

- Verify any attendance figures with an official source before quoting.
- Next: Ayodhya, Mathura, Vrindavan. Site Profile 1 begins.

Ayodhya, Mathura and Vrindavan

OBJECTIVES — STUDENTS CAN:

1. Locate Ayodhya, Mathura and Vrindavan and their rivers.
2. Explain how sacred narratives map onto real landscapes.
3. Describe how 16th-century bhakti movements shaped Braj pilgrimage.
4. Discuss contested sites accurately and respectfully.

TIMING

Wonder	3 min	0:00–0:03
Learn	7 min	0:03–0:10
Map	3 min	0:10–0:13
Explore	9 min	0:13–0:22
Quiz	5 min	0:22–0:27
Reflect	3 min	0:27–0:30

KEY TERMS

Braj	BRUJ	Krishna's home region
parikrama	pa-ri-KRUH-maa	circling pilgrimage route
lila	LEE-laa	divine play
bhakti	BHUK-tee	devotion

Materials: presentation (Class 8), student handout for Class 8, passports or notebooks, South Asia map.

Wonder 3 min

"What happens when a place is sacred because of a story?"

> What happens when a place becomes sacred because of a story? Think of fans visiting real locations from a favorite book or film. How do people decide where a story 'happened'?

Teacher move: Note that people often identify, mark and revisit story locations, and that these places gain meaning through that practice over time.

Learn 7 min

1. Ayodhya

> Ayodhya stands on the Sarayu river in Uttar Pradesh. In the Ramayana it is the capital of Rama's kingdom. When Rama returns after fourteen years of exile and the defeat of Ravana, the city lights lamps to welcome him; many families in North India connect Diwali with this homecoming.

2. Mathura and Vrindavan

> Mathura and Vrindavan lie on the Yamuna, about 15 kilometers apart, in a region called Braj. Many traditions honor Mathura as the birthplace of Krishna and Vrindavan as the setting of his youth: herding cows, playing the flute, lifting Govardhan hill to shelter villagers from a storm. These episodes are called Krishna's lila, his divine play.

3. Mapping a sacred landscape

> Much of today's Braj pilgrimage landscape was shaped in the 16th century. Followers of the Bengali saint Chaitanya and of the teacher Vallabhacharya traveled to Braj, identified groves, ponds and hills linked with Krishna stories, and built temples. Pilgrims still walk the long Braj parikrama route connecting these sites.

4. Narrative and history

> Sacred narrative, archaeology and written records answer different questions. Some sacred sites are also at the center of modern political and legal disputes. Ayodhya's Babri Masjid–Ram Janmabhoomi dispute was decided by India's Supreme Court in 2019, and the Ram Mandir was consecrated in January 2024. In class, we separate the story, the historical evidence and the modern dispute.

Check for understanding: *How might a story become attached to a specific pond or hill?*

Map 3 min

Tap each numbered site on the screen as you speak.

#	SITE	WHERE	WHAT TO SAY
1	**Ayodhya**	Uttar Pradesh	City on the Sarayu river. In the Ramayana, Rama's home and capital.
2	**Mathura**	Uttar Pradesh	On the Yamuna. Many traditions honor it as Krishna's birthplace.
3	**Vrindavan**	Uttar Pradesh	Town of Krishna's childhood stories, full of temples and devotional songs.

Explore 9 min

Step 1 · Whole class (2–3 min)

Place story events on the map of the Braj region and Ayodhya.

ANSWER KEY

Matching game: Place and story

TERM	MATCH
Ayodhya	Rama's capital and return
Mathura	Krishna's birth
Vrindavan	Krishna's youth with the gopis
Govardhan	Krishna lifts a hill to shelter villagers
Sarayu	River of Ayodhya
Yamuna	River of Braj

Map game: Find it on the map

Students tap each named site on the map: Ayodhya, Mathura, Vrindavan.

Step 2 · Task (4–5 min)

> Read the two short passages on your sheet: a devotional description of Vrindavan and a historian's account of how Braj sites were identified. In pairs, list what each emphasizes and what each leaves out. Then write one sentence on why both are valuable.

Prompts for groups that get stuck:

- Which passage uses emotional or devotional language?
- Which mentions dates, people and evidence?
- What would a devotee say the historian misses?
- What would a historian say the devotional text cannot prove?

Step 3 · Discussion (2 min)

"How should a classroom discuss sacred sites that are also politically contested, while staying accurate and respectful to everyone?"

Look for: Good classroom norms: separate the narrative, the evidence and the dispute; use precise language; avoid repeating social media claims; recognize that people in the room may feel strongly; focus on understanding, not winning.

Quiz 5 min

Students answer individually (fingers 1–4 or on the handout) before you reveal.

#	QUESTION	ANSWER	WHY
1	Which 16th-century movements helped revive Braj pilgrimage sites?	**A** Followers of Chaitanya and Vallabhacharya	They identified sites linked to Krishna stories.
2	Mathura and Vrindavan lie on which river?	**A** Yamuna	The Braj region follows the Yamuna.
3	What does lila mean in Krishna devotion?	**B** Divine play	Stories of Krishna's lila shape the landscape.
4	The best approach to a contested sacred site in class is...	**D** Separate the narrative, the historical evidence and the modern dispute	Clear distinctions keep the discussion accurate.

Reflect 3 min

Passport prompt: Start Site Profile 1: choose a site and list three sources of different types you will use.

Model answer: *Site Profile 1 start: "I will study Vrindavan using a devotional text, a historian's account of 16th-century site identification, and a photograph of the Banke Bihari temple."*

Exit ticket: one word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

Next class: Sunday, January 10, 2027 — Class 9–10: Himalayan Sacred Landscapes.

Teacher background

Assign Site Profile 1 today (due January 10). Students choose one site and use three sources of different types. Middle-ground guidance: one page, a map, three sources cited.

Questions students may ask

"Who was right in the Ayodhya case?"

State the fact: the Supreme Court awarded the disputed site for a temple in 2019 and allotted separate land for a mosque. Avoid editorializing.

"Did Krishna really live there?"

For devotees, Braj is Krishna's land. Historians study how that belief shaped the region's temples and pilgrimage.

Quick notes

- Keep the Ayodhya dispute brief and factual; the focus is how narratives map onto places.
- Winter break Dec 20 – Jan 3. Site Profile 1 due Jan 10.

Himalayan Sacred Landscapes

OBJECTIVES — STUDENTS CAN:

1. Identify the four shrines of the Chota Char Dham and their deities.
2. Explain how seasons, altitude and climate shape Himalayan pilgrimage.
3. Analyze how borders affect access to Kailash, Manasarovar and Pashupatinath.
4. Evaluate policies such as visitor caps for fragile mountain sites.

TIMING

Wonder	3 min	0:00–0:03
Learn	7 min	0:03–0:10
Map	3 min	0:10–0:13
Explore	9 min	0:13–0:22
Quiz	5 min	0:22–0:27
Reflect	3 min	0:27–0:30

KEY TERMS

dham	DHAAM	abode; holy seat
kora / parikrama	KOR-a	circumambulation route
carrying capacity	—	how many visitors a place can safely support

Materials: presentation (Class 9–10), student handout for Class 9–10, passports or notebooks, South Asia map.

Wonder 3 min

“What happens to a pilgrimage when its sacred places sit in fragile mountains across national borders?”

> What happens to a pilgrimage when its sacred places sit in fragile mountains, and some of them across national borders? Think about weather, roads, permits and politics. What could make a journey impossible?

Teacher move: Collect constraints: snow, landslides, altitude sickness, closed borders, permits, cost. Note today combines two curriculum classes, so pace briskly.

Learn 7 min

1. The Chota Char Dham

> The Chota Char Dham, the ‘small four abodes,’ are four Himalayan shrines in Uttarakhand: Yamunotri, honoring the river goddess Yamuna; Gangotri, honoring Ganga; Kedarnath, a Shiva Jyotirlinga at about 3,580 meters; and Badrinath, a Vishnu temple. Pilgrims traditionally visit them from west to east.

2. A fragile landscape

> Seasons decide everything. Heavy snow closes the temples each winter, usually from around October–November to April–May, and worship moves to lower ‘winter seats.’ Opening and closing dates are announced each year according to the Hindu calendar.

3. Kailash and Manasarovar

> These valleys are fragile. In June 2013, a cloudburst and glacial-lake flood devastated Kedarnath and killed thousands of people. Since then, debates have grown over road widening, hydropower projects, helicopter traffic and how many pilgrims the valleys can safely hold, a concept called carrying capacity.

4. Pashupatinath

> Some Himalayan sacred places lie beyond India. Mount Kailash and Lake Manasarovar are in Tibet, governed by China; they are sacred to Hindus, Buddhists, Jains and followers of Bon. Pilgrims walk around Kailash, about 52 kilometers, and never climb it; access depends on permits and India–China relations. Pashupatinath, a great Shiva temple, stands on the Bagmati river in Kathmandu, Nepal.

Check for understanding: *Why might a mountain be considered too sacred to climb?*

Map 3 min

Tap each numbered site on the screen as you speak.

#	SITE	WHERE	WHAT TO SAY
1	**Yamunotri**	Uttarakhand	Temple of Goddess Yamuna, near the source of the Yamuna river.
2	**Gangotri**	Uttarakhand	Temple of Goddess Ganga, near the glacier where the river begins.
3	**Kedarnath**	Uttarakhand	Shiva temple at about 3,580 m. One of the 12 Jyotirlingas.
4	**Badrinath**	Uttarakhand	Vishnu temple (Badrinarayan) on the Alaknanda river. Part of both Char Dham circuits.
5	**Mount Kailash**	Tibet (China)	Mountain linked with Shiva. Pilgrims walk around it (about 52 km) instead of climbing it.
6	**Lake Manasarovar**	Tibet (China)	High-altitude lake near Kailash, honored in Hindu, Buddhist and Jain traditions.
7	**Pashupatinath**	Kathmandu, Nepal	Shiva temple on the Bagmati river, part of the Kathmandu Valley World Heritage Site.

Explore 9 min

Step 1 · Whole class (2–3 min)

Trace the Chota Char Dham on the relief map, then add the sites across the borders.

ANSWER KEY

Ordering game: Chota Char Dham, west to east

1. Yamunotri
2. Gangotri
3. Kedarnath
4. Badrinath

Map game: Himalayan map game

Students tap each named site on the map: Yamunotri, Gangotri, Kedarnath, Badrinath, Mount Kailash, Pashupatinath.

Step 2 · Task (4–5 min)

> Design a low-impact itinerary for the Chota Char Dham using the elevation and season information on your sheet. Then propose one policy to protect the valleys, such as permits, daily caps or electric shuttles, and name who might object and why.

Prompts for groups that get stuck:

- How many days for acclimatization?
- Which month balances weather and crowds?
- Who earns a living from pilgrims?
- Would a cap be fair to poorer pilgrims?

Step 3 · Discussion (2 min)

"Should governments cap the number of pilgrims at sacred mountain sites? Who should decide?"

Look for: Arguments for caps: safety, environment, quality of experience. Against: limits devotion, hurts local livelihoods, may favor the wealthy if tied to fees. Strong answers suggest fair mechanisms like free lotteries or registration.

Quiz 5 min

Students answer individually (fingers 1–4 or on the handout) before you reveal.

#	QUESTION	ANSWER	WHY
1	What disaster in 2013 reshaped debate about Himalayan pilgrimage?	**D** The Kedarnath flood	Thousands died in the flash floods.
2	Why can access to Kailash change from year to year?	**D** It depends on permits and India–China relations	Borders shape sacred journeys.
3	Which traditions hold Kailash sacred?	**A** Hindu, Buddhist, Jain and Bon	A shared sacred landscape.
4	What is "carrying capacity"?	**A** How many visitors a place can safely support	A key idea in sustainable tourism.

Reflect 3 min

Passport prompt: Turn in Site Profile 1. Write one paragraph: how do environment and borders shape Himalayan pilgrimage?

Model answer: *Himalayan pilgrimage is shaped by snow, altitude and floods that limit when people can travel, and by borders that make Kailash dependent on permits and diplomacy.*

Exit ticket: one word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

Next class: Sunday, January 24, 2027 — Class 11: The All-India Char Dham.

Teacher background

Collect Site Profile 1 today. Since 2022 Uttarakhand has used mandatory pilgrim registration for the Char Dham Yatra. The Kailash Manasarovar Yatra via India was suspended for several years and resumed in 2025; check

current status before mentioning.

Questions students may ask

"Why not build a cable car to every temple?"

Some are planned or built. Benefits include access; concerns include ecology, cost and changing the pilgrimage's meaning.

"Why do Buddhists honor Kailash too?"

In Buddhist tradition it is the home of the deity Chakrasamvara; Jains link it with the first Tirthankara. Shared sacred geography is common in the Himalayas.

Quick notes

- This session combines curriculum Classes 9 and 10.
- Highlight the cluster in Uttarakhand and the border crossings.
- Profile 1 due today. No class Jan 17.

The All-India Char Dham

OBJECTIVES — STUDENTS CAN:

1. Locate the four dhams of the all-India Char Dham.
2. Explain the tradition linking the circuit to Adi Shankaracharya.
3. Compare the all-India and Himalayan Char Dham circuits.
4. Evaluate whether pilgrimage circuits unify or exclude.

TIMING

Wonder	3 min	0:00–0:03
Learn	7 min	0:03–0:10
Map	3 min	0:10–0:13
Explore	9 min	0:13–0:22
Quiz	5 min	0:22–0:27
Reflect	3 min	0:27–0:30

KEY TERMS

matha	MUTT	monastery
Advaita	ad-VAI-ta	non-dual philosophy
Vaishnava / Shaiva	VAISH-na-va / SHAI-va	devoted to Vishnu / Shiva

Materials: presentation (Class 11), student handout for Class 11, passports or notebooks, South Asia map.

Wonder 3 min

"Can a pilgrimage route create a sense of one shared land?"

> Can a pilgrimage route create a sense of one shared land? Imagine visiting all four edges of a large country. Would you feel more connected to it afterward? Why?

Teacher move: Connect to American examples like national parks road trips. Note that the Char Dham predates modern India by many centuries.

Learn 7 min

1. Four directions

> The all-India Char Dham marks the four directions of the subcontinent. In the north, Badrinath in the Himalayas. In the west, Dwarka on the Arabian Sea in Gujarat. In the east, Puri on the Bay of Bengal in Odisha. In the south, Rameswaram on an island in Tamil Nadu. Visiting all four means crossing the whole land.

2. Adi Shankaracharya

> Tradition credits the 8th-century philosopher Adi Shankaracharya, teacher of Advaita Vedanta, with founding monasteries called mathas in four directions: Badrinath area (Jyotirmath), Dwarka, Puri and Sringeri. These connected scholars and pilgrims across vast distances. Historians debate the exact details, but the tradition shaped how the circuit is understood.

3. Diversity within unity

> The circuit joins different traditions. Badrinath honors Vishnu; Dwarka honors Krishna as King Dwarkadhish; Puri honors Jagannath, a form of Krishna, with his brother and sister; Rameswaram honors Shiva, linked with Rama. Languages, foods and rituals differ at every stop, yet all four are seen as one circuit.

4. Pilgrimage and nation

> Some historians argue that circuits like this helped people imagine the subcontinent as a connected sacred space long before the modern nation-state. Others note that long, costly journeys were open mainly to those with time and money, and that some temples restricted entry by caste in the past.

Check for understanding: *What does it mean that one circuit joins Vishnu and Shiva sites?*

Map 3 min

Tap each numbered site on the screen as you speak.

#	SITE	WHERE	WHAT TO SAY
1	**Badrinath**	Uttarakhand	Vishnu temple (Badrinarayan) on the Alaknanda river. Part of both Char Dham circuits.
2	**Dwarka**	Gujarat	Western Char Dham. Dwarkadhish temple of Krishna beside the Arabian Sea.
3	**Puri**	Odisha	Eastern Char Dham. Jagannath temple and the Rath Yatra chariot festival.
4	**Rameswaram**	Tamil Nadu	Island temple town. Southern Char Dham with very long pillared corridors.

Explore 9 min

Step 1 · Whole class (2–3 min)

Place the four dhams on a compass map and complete the deity–landscape–food–festival puzzle.

ANSWER KEY

Sort game: Which direction?

GROUP	CARDS THAT BELONG
North	Badrinath
West	Dwarka
East	Puri
South	Rameswaram

Matching game: Site, deity, setting

TERM	MATCH
Badrinath	Vishnu, Himalayan valley
Dwarka	Krishna, Arabian Sea coast
Puri	Jagannath, Bay of Bengal coast
Rameswaram	Shiva, island in the Gulf of Mannar

Step 2 · Task (4–5 min)

> In groups, compare the all-India Char Dham with the Himalayan Chota Char Dham on four points: purpose, geography, deities, and who could realistically complete each in the past and today. Fill the comparison table on your sheet.

Prompts for groups that get stuck:

- Distance: thousands of km versus a single valley region.
- Seasonal access differs.
- Both include Badrinath. Why?
- Travel time a century ago versus today.

Step 3 · Discussion (2 min)

"Do pilgrimage circuits unify a diverse country, or can they also exclude people? Give examples."

Look for: Unify: shared sacred map, pilgrims mixing across regions and languages. Exclude: cost, distance, past caste restrictions, gender rules at some sites. Strong answers give a specific example for each.

Quiz 5 min

Students answer individually (fingers 1–4 or on the handout) before you reveal.

#	QUESTION	ANSWER	WHY
1	Which philosopher does tradition link with the four dhams?	**C** Adi Shankaracharya	Associated with four mathas.
2	Which dham honors Shiva?	**D** Rameswaram	Its deity is Ramanathaswamy.
3	Historians argue such circuits helped people...	**D** Imagine a connected sacred land	Long before the modern nation-state.
4	How does it differ from the Chota Char Dham?	**A** It spans all four directions of India	The Chota Char Dham is in Uttarakhand.

Reflect 3 min

Passport prompt: Explain in one paragraph what connects the four dhams beyond geography.

Model answer: *Beyond geography, the four dhams are connected by a shared tradition that maps the whole land as sacred and links Vaishnava and Shaiva devotion into one journey.*

Exit ticket: one word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

Next class: Sunday, January 31, 2027 — Class 12: Shiva and the Jyotirlinga Network.

Teacher background

Jyotirmath (Joshimath) has been affected by land subsidence since 2023. Sringeri in Karnataka is the southern matha; Rameswaram is the southern dham. Students sometimes confuse the two lists.

Questions students may ask

"Did Shankaracharya really found all four?"

Tradition says so; historians debate the details. We present it as tradition.

"Do people still do all four?"

Yes; tour operators and railways run Char Dham packages, often in a few weeks.

Quick notes

- Next: the Jyotirlinga network.

Shiva and the Jyotirlinga Network

OBJECTIVES — STUDENTS CAN:

1. Explain the Jyotirlinga story and what 'aniconic' means.
2. Locate five of the twelve Jyotirlingas and describe their settings.
3. Analyze competing claims to Jyotirlinga status.
4. Argue whether a rebuilt temple is the same sacred place.

TIMING

Wonder	3 min	0:00–0:03
Learn	7 min	0:03–0:10
Map	3 min	0:10–0:13
Explore	9 min	0:13–0:22
Quiz	5 min	0:22–0:27
Reflect	3 min	0:27–0:30

KEY TERMS

linga	LING-a	aniconic form of Shiva
aniconic	an-eye-KON-ik	not shaped like a figure
Mahakaleshwar	ma-haa-kaa-LAYSH-war	Shiva as lord of time, Ujjain

Materials: presentation (Class 12), student handout for Class 12, passports or notebooks, South Asia map.

Wonder 3 min

"Why would a tradition count exactly twelve sacred sites, and what happens when communities disagree on the list?"

> Why would a tradition count exactly twelve sacred sites? And what happens when two towns both claim to be one of them? Think about why lists matter to communities.

Teacher move: Draw out that numbered lists give structure to pilgrimage and bring prestige, pilgrims and income, so being on the list matters.

Learn 7 min

1. Linga of light

> A story in the Puranas tells of Brahma and Vishnu arguing over who was greater. Shiva appeared between them as an endless pillar of light. Brahma flew up and Vishnu dug down, but neither found its end. Jyotirlinga means 'linga of light,' and each Jyotirlinga site is linked with this radiant form of Shiva.

2. Twelve sites

> The linga is an aniconic form of Shiva, meaning it does not look like a human figure. It is usually a smooth, rounded stone on a base. For many devotees, it represents Shiva as formless and infinite. Twelve Jyotirlinga temples are spread across India, and a well-known Sanskrit hymn lists them.

3. Somnath

> Somnath on the Gujarat coast is often listed first. In 1026 it was raided by Mahmud of Ghazni, and it was destroyed and rebuilt several times over the centuries. After independence, the present temple was rebuilt and completed in 1951, becoming a powerful symbol of renewal. Other Jyotirlingas include Kashi Vishwanath, Mahakaleshwar in Ujjain, Kedarnath and Ramanathaswamy.

4. Contested lists

> For a few of the twelve, more than one temple claims the title. Vaidyanath is claimed by Deoghar in Jharkhand and Parli in Maharashtra; Nageshwar has rival claimants in Gujarat and Maharashtra; Bhimashankar too. These disputes reflect local pride, regional traditions and different readings of the texts.

Check for understanding: *If a temple is rebuilt from scratch, what stays the same?*

Map 3 min

Tap each numbered site on the screen as you speak.

#	SITE	WHERE	WHAT TO SAY
1	**Somnath**	Gujarat	Seaside Jyotirlinga temple, rebuilt many times. The present temple dates from 1951.
2	**Varanasi (Kashi)**	Uttar Pradesh	Ancient city on the Ganga with stone ghats and the Kashi Vishwanath temple of Shiva.
3	**Ujjain (Mahakaleshwar)**	Madhya Pradesh	Mahakaleshwar Jyotirlinga on the Shipra river. One of the four Kumbh Mela cities.
4	**Kedarnath**	Uttarakhand	Shiva temple at about 3,580 m. One of the 12 Jyotirlingas.
5	**Rameswaram**	Tamil Nadu	Island temple town. Southern Char Dham with very long pillared corridors.

Explore 9 min

Step 1 · Whole class (2–3 min)

Connect five Jyotirlinga sites with yarn on the map and note the landscapes.

ANSWER KEY

Sort game: Coast, river or mountain?

GROUP	CARDS THAT BELONG
Seacoast	Somnath · Ramanathaswamy, Rameswaram
Riverbank	Kashi Vishwanath · Mahakaleshwar (Shipra river)
Mountains	Kedarnath

Map game: Find the Jyotirlingas

Students tap each named site on the map: Somnath, Varanasi (Kashi), Ujjain (Mahakaleshwar), Kedarnath, Rameswaram.

Step 2 · Task (4–5 min)

> Choose one contested Jyotirlinga claim from the slide. Identify the competing sites, the kind of evidence each community points to, and explain why the dispute matters locally. Three minutes in pairs, then share.

Prompts for groups that get stuck:

- What texts or traditions does each site cite?
- What would a town gain from recognition?
- Can both claims be 'true' for their communities?
- How would a historian approach this?

Step 3 · Discussion (2 min)

"Somnath has been destroyed and rebuilt many times. Is a rebuilt temple the same sacred place?"

Look for: Arguments for continuity: the place, the linga, the community and ritual continue. Arguments for change: new materials, new meanings, a modern political symbol. Strong answers recognize that sacredness may live in place and practice more than in stones.

Quiz 5 min

Students answer individually (fingers 1–4 or on the handout) before you reveal.

#	QUESTION	ANSWER	WHY
1	What does aniconic mean?	**A** Not shaped like a human or animal figure	The linga is an aniconic form.
2	When was the present Somnath temple completed?	**B** 1951	It became a symbol after independence.
3	Which Jyotirlinga has rival claimants in Jharkhand and Maharashtra?	**A** Vaidyanath	Deoghar and Parli both claim it.
4	Mahakaleshwar is in which city?	**A** Ujjain	On the Shipra river.

Reflect 3 min

Passport prompt: Argue whether a rebuilt temple is the same sacred place. Use Somnath as evidence.

Model answer: *A rebuilt temple can remain the same sacred place because its location, deity and community of worship continue, as Somnath shows across many rebuildings.*

Exit ticket: one word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

Next class: Sunday, February 7, 2027 — Class 13: Shakti Peethas and Goddess Traditions.

Teacher background

The twelve commonly listed: Somnath, Mallikarjuna (Srisailam), Mahakaleshwar, Omkareshwar, Kedarnath, Bhimashankar, Kashi Vishwanath, Trimbakeshwar, Vaidyanath, Nageshwar, Ramanathaswamy, Grishneshwar. Mahashivaratri in 2027 falls in early March; confirm with a panchang.

Questions students may ask

"Why was Somnath raided?"
It was a very wealthy temple; raids targeted wealth and power. Present the facts without generalizing about any community today.

"What is the Bhasma Aarti?"
A dawn ritual at Mahakaleshwar in Ujjain where the linga is offered sacred ash.

Quick notes

- Mahashivaratri falls in early 2027; confirm the date with a panchang before mentioning it.
- Next: Goddess traditions.

Shakti Peethas and Goddess Traditions

OBJECTIVES — STUDENTS CAN:

1. Explain Shakti and Shakta traditions of the Goddess.
2. Retell the Shakti Peetha story briefly and with care.
3. Compare four Goddess shrines and their settings.
4. Explain why sacred-site lists differ within one tradition.

TIMING

Wonder	3 min	0:00–0:03
Learn	7 min	0:03–0:10
Map	3 min	0:10–0:13
Explore	9 min	0:13–0:22
Quiz	5 min	0:22–0:27
Reflect	3 min	0:27–0:30

KEY TERMS

Shakta	SHAAK-ta	devotee of the Goddess
peetha	PEE-tha	seat
Tantra	TUN-tra	ritual and esoteric tradition

Materials: presentation (Class 13), student handout for Class 13, passports or notebooks, South Asia map.

Wonder 3 min

"What can goddess traditions tell us about how power and the divine are imagined?"

> What can traditions about the Goddess tell us about how people imagine power and the divine? In many cultures, power is pictured as male. What changes if ultimate power is imagined as female?

Teacher move: Accept a range of answers; emphasize that goddess traditions show both fierce and nurturing forms of power.

Learn 7 min

1. Shakti and Devi

> Shakti means power or energy. In Shakta traditions, the Goddess, called Devi, is the supreme divine power. She appears in many forms: fierce protectors such as Durga and Kali, and nurturing or auspicious forms such as Parvati and Lakshmi. Festivals like Navaratri and Durga Puja celebrate her.

2. The Shakti Peetha story

> The Shakti Peetha story tells of Sati, daughter of King Daksha and wife of Shiva. Insulted by her father, she gave up her life. Grieving Shiva carried her body across the universe, and Vishnu released him from grief by dividing it; wherever parts fell, the land became a seat, or peetha, of the Goddess. Different texts count 4, 18, 51, 52 or 108 such places.

3. Case studies

> Four case studies. Kamakhya, on Nilachal Hill above the Brahmaputra in Guwahati, Assam, is a major center of Tantric worship and hosts the Ambubachi Mela each June. Kalighat in Kolkata honors Kali. Vaishno Devi is a cave shrine in the Trikuta mountains of Jammu, reached by a long walk from Katra. Kamakshi Amman is a great Goddess temple in Kanchipuram, Tamil Nadu.

4. Mapping power

> Scholars note that the story turns the whole subcontinent into the Goddess's body, linking local goddesses in many regions into one network. Because lists come from different texts, regions and eras, they don't agree. That is not a mistake; it is what diversity within one tradition looks like.

Check for understanding: *How does the Shakti Peetha story change the way someone might see a map?*

Map 3 min

Tap each numbered site on the screen as you speak.

#	SITE	WHERE	WHAT TO SAY
1	**Kamakhya**	Assam	Goddess temple on Nilachal Hill above the Brahmaputra, in Guwahati.
2	**Kalighat**	West Bengal	Temple of Kali in Kolkata, beside an old channel of the Hooghly river.
3	**Vaishno Devi**	Jammu & Kashmir	Cave shrine of the Goddess in the Trikuta mountains, reached by a long uphill walk from Katra.
4	**Kanchipuram**	Tamil Nadu	Temple town of Kamakshi Amman, also famous for silk weaving.

Explore 9 min

Step 1 · Whole class (2–3 min)

Compare images, landscapes and community descriptions of the four shrines.

ANSWER KEY

Matching game: Shrine and setting

TERM	MATCH
Kamakhya	Hilltop above the Brahmaputra, Tantric center
Kalighat	Kolkata, beside the old Hooghly channel
Vaishno Devi	Cave shrine in the Trikuta mountains
Kamakshi Amman	Temple town of Kanchipuram

Map game: Find the Goddess shrines

Students tap each named site on the map: Kamakhya, Kalighat, Vaishno Devi, Kanchipuram.

Step 2 · Task (4–5 min)

> Look at the seven Goddess shrines on your sheet, spread across five countries. Lists of Shakti Peethas differ: a shrine may appear in one tradition's list and not another's. In pairs, suggest at least two reasons lists might

> differ, such as region, sect, era or the politics of pilgrimage, and say which shrines show that sacred geography crosses modern borders.

Prompts for groups that get stuck:

- Where might each list have been written?
- Would a temple want to be on the list? Why?
- Which shrines are outside India today?
- Can different lists each be authoritative for their own community?

Step 3 · Discussion (2 min)

"What does it mean for a land to be imagined as a goddess's body? Compare with other traditions that sanctify land."

Look for: Imagining land as the Goddess's body makes the whole map sacred and connects distant regions. Compare with ideas like 'Mother Earth' or sacred homelands in other traditions.

Quiz 5 min

Students answer individually (fingers 1–4 or on the handout) before you reveal.

#	QUESTION	ANSWER	WHY
1	Shakta traditions treat the Goddess as...	**A** Supreme divine power	Shakti is the ultimate reality.
2	Why do Shakti Peetha counts vary (4 to 108)?	**B** Different texts, regions and sects list different sites	Diversity within one tradition.
3	Which shrine is a major Tantric center?	**C** Kamakhya	On Nilachal Hill in Guwahati.
4	How do scholars read the scattered-body story?	**C** As linking regional goddesses into one network	Geography becomes theology.

Reflect 3 min

Passport prompt: Answer: what does diversity within one tradition look like? Use evidence from today.

Model answer: *Diversity within one tradition looks like different lists of Shakti Peethas, different forms of the Goddess, and different rituals, all recognized as part of one Shakta tradition.*

Exit ticket: one word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

Next class: Sunday, February 21, 2027 — Class 14: Vishnu and Krishna Pilgrimage Centers.

Teacher background

Tell the Sati story briefly and gently; focus on the result: many sacred seats across the land. Several Shakti Peethas lie outside India, including Hinglaj in Pakistan and Guhyeshwari in Nepal.

Questions students may ask

"Is Kali scary?"

Kali's fierce form represents destroying evil and ego. Many devotees see her as a loving mother.

"Why do some temples allow animal sacrifice?"

Some Shakta temples, including Kamakhya, have this practice; others reject it. Describe factually.

Quick notes

- Tell the Sati story briefly and with care.
- No class Feb 14. Next class Feb 21.

Vishnu and Krishna Pilgrimage Centers

OBJECTIVES — STUDENTS CAN:

1. Describe major Vishnu and Krishna pilgrimage centers.
2. Explain how a large temple works as an institution and economy.
3. Create a systems diagram of a temple's inputs and outputs.
4. Evaluate debates over who should manage temple funds.

TIMING

Wonder	3 min	0:00–0:03
Learn	7 min	0:03–0:10
Map	3 min	0:10–0:13
Explore	9 min	0:13–0:22
Quiz	5 min	0:22–0:27
Reflect	3 min	0:27–0:30

KEY TERMS

Devasthanam	day-vu-STHAA-num	temple trust
hundi	HOON-dee	offering box
Sri Vaishnava	SHREE VAISH-na-va	South Indian Vishnu tradition

Materials: presentation (Class 14), student handout for Class 14, passports or notebooks, South Asia map.

Wonder 3 min

"Is a large temple more like a place of worship, a city government or a business?"

> Is a large temple more like a place of worship, a city government, or a business? A temple might employ thousands, cook meals for tens of thousands and run schools. Pick one comparison and defend it.

Teacher move: Accept all three; the best answer is that it is all of them at once. That tension drives today's discussion.

Learn 7 min

1. Tirumala-Tirupati

> Tirumala, in the hills above Tirupati in Andhra Pradesh, is the shrine of Venkateswara, a form of Vishnu. It is among the most visited and wealthiest religious sites in the world. It is managed by the Tirumala Tirupati Devasthanams, or TTD, which also runs schools, hospitals and free meals. Its laddu prasad is famous, and many pilgrims offer their hair as a vow.

2. Srirangam

> Srirangam, on an island between the Kaveri and Kollidam rivers in Tamil Nadu, holds the Ranganathaswamy temple, with Vishnu reclining on the serpent Adishesha. Its seven concentric walls enclose streets, homes and markets. It is a center of the Sri Vaishnava tradition associated with the 11th–12th-century teacher Ramanuja.

3. Puri and Guruvayur

> At Puri's Jagannath temple, the kitchen cooks mahaprasad in stacked clay pots over wood fires, feeding thousands daily; new pots are used each day. At Guruvayur in Kerala, Krishna is worshipped as Guruvayurappan, and the temple keeps a herd of elephants that take part in festivals. Dwarka, the western dham, honors Krishna as King Dwarkadhish.

4. Temples as institutions

> Large temples are institutions. Offerings collected in the hundi, the offering box, fund staff, food, maintenance and charity. In many Indian states, major temples are administered by government-appointed boards under state laws. Some argue this ensures accountability; others argue that religious communities should manage their own temples and funds.

Check for understanding: *What surprised you about what a large temple does besides worship?*

Map 3 min

Tap each numbered site on the screen as you speak.

#	SITE	WHERE	WHAT TO SAY
1	**Tirumala-Tirupati**	Andhra Pradesh	Hilltop temple of Venkateswara, one of the most visited temples in the world.
2	**Srirangam**	Tamil Nadu	Ranganathaswamy temple on an island in the Kaveri river.
3	**Dwarka**	Gujarat	Western Char Dham. Dwarkadhish temple of Krishna beside the Arabian Sea.
4	**Puri**	Odisha	Eastern Char Dham. Jagannath temple and the Rath Yatra chariot festival.
5	**Guruvayur**	Kerala	Krishna temple (Guruvayurappan) known for its elephants and music.

Explore 9 min

Step 1 · Whole class (2–3 min)

Explore how a temple is a worship space, kitchen, workplace, archive and community center.

ANSWER KEY

Matching game: Temple roles

TERM	MATCH
Archaka (priest)	Performs daily rituals
Kitchen staff	Prepare prasad and free meals
Nadaswaram players	Music for rituals and processions
Temple board	Manages funds and administration
Volunteers	Crowd guidance and food service
Mahout	Cares for temple elephants

Map game: Find the temples

Students tap each named site on the map: Tirumala-Tirupati, Srirangam, Dwarka, Puri, Guruvayur.

Step 2 · Task (4–5 min)

> Build a systems diagram for a large temple. On the left, inputs: donations, food supplies, volunteers, staff. In the middle, processes: rituals, cooking, administration. On the right, outputs: meals, festivals, schools, records. Then circle one point of tension, such as who decides how donations are spent.

Prompts for groups that get stuck:

- Where does the money come from and go?
- Who decides the temple calendar?
- What happens when crowds exceed capacity?
- Which outputs serve people who never enter the temple?

Step 3 · Discussion (2 min)

"Should temples be managed by governments, independent trusts or devotee communities? Weigh accountability and autonomy."

Look for: Government boards: accountability, anti-corruption, public safety. Independent trusts or community control: religious autonomy, local knowledge, avoiding political interference. Strong answers recognize trade-offs and propose safeguards.

Quiz 5 min

Students answer individually (fingers 1–4 or on the handout) before you reveal.

#	QUESTION	ANSWER	WHY
1	What is the TTD?	**D** The trust that manages the Tirumala temple	It runs schools and hospitals too.
2	Srirangam is closely associated with which teacher?	**A** Ramanuja	A center of Sri Vaishnavism.
3	What is a hundi?	**D** A temple offering box	Donations fund temple operations.

4	What debate surrounds many large temples?	**A** Who should control temple funds	Government vs. community management.

Reflect 3 min

Passport prompt: Begin Site Profile 2. Include a systems diagram for your chosen site.

Model answer: *Site Profile 2 start: a systems diagram of Tirumala showing donations and volunteers flowing into rituals and kitchens, producing free meals, schools and festivals.*

Exit ticket: one word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

Next class: Sunday, February 28, 2027 — Class 15: Festivals that Move the Deity.

Teacher background

Assign Site Profile 2 today (due April 18): one site, a systems diagram or analysis, and three sources. The TTD's annual budget runs to several thousand crore rupees; check the latest figure before quoting.

Questions students may ask

"Why do pilgrims shave their heads at Tirumala?"
Offering hair is a vow of humility and gratitude for many devotees.

"Is it fair that temples are rich?"
Many temples fund charity, but debates continue. Present multiple views.

Quick notes

- Site Profile 2 due Apr 18.

Festivals that Move the Deity

OBJECTIVES — STUDENTS CAN:

1. Describe four festivals in which the deity leaves the temple.
2. Explain what processions reveal about community and belonging.
3. Plan crowd management for a festival route.
4. Analyze the social significance of the Pandharpur Wari.

TIMING

Wonder	3 min	0:00–0:03
Learn	7 min	0:03–0:10
Map	3 min	0:10–0:13
Explore	9 min	0:13–0:22
Quiz	5 min	0:22–0:27
Reflect	3 min	0:27–0:30

KEY TERMS

rath	RUTH	chariot
palkhi	PAAL-khee	palanquin
abhang	a-BHUNG	Marathi devotional song
Warkari	WAAR-ka-ree	Wari pilgrim

Materials: presentation (Class 15), student handout for Class 15, passports or notebooks, South Asia map.

Wonder 3 min

“What changes when the sacred leaves the temple and enters public streets?”

> What changes when the sacred leaves the temple and enters public streets? Think about who can see the deity now who could not before, and what the city has to do to prepare.

Teacher move: Point out that inside temples, access may be limited; in the street, anyone can have darshan. Processions also turn the whole city into sacred space for a day.

Learn 7 min

1. Rath Yatra, Puri

> In Puri’s Rath Yatra, held each June or July, Jagannath, his brother Balabhadra and sister Subhadra leave the temple on three enormous wooden chariots, rebuilt from fresh timber every year. Thousands of people pull them about 3 kilometers to the Gundicha temple. The English word ‘juggernaut’ comes from European accounts of these huge chariots.

2. Chithirai Festival, Madurai

> In Madurai, the Chithirai Festival each April–May celebrates the divine wedding of the goddess Meenakshi and Sundareswarar, a form of Shiva. It joins with a second festival, in which Kallazhagar, a form of Vishnu, travels to the Vaigai river. The festival links Shaiva and Vaishnava traditions in one city-wide celebration.

3. Karthigai Deepam

> At Tiruvannamalai in Tamil Nadu, the festival of Karthigai Deepam each November–December ends with a great lamp lit on top of Arunachala hill, visible for miles. In local tradition the hill itself is Shiva as a column of fire, connecting to the Jyotirlinga story we learned in January.

4. Pandharpur Wari

> In Maharashtra, the Pandharpur Wari is a walking pilgrimage of about 250 kilometers over roughly three weeks, arriving for Ashadhi Ekadashi in June–July. Pilgrims called Warkaris carry palanquins, called palkhis, with the sandals of the saints Dnyaneshwar and Tukaram, singing their devotional songs, called abhangs. The Wari has long welcomed people of every caste.

Check for understanding: *Why might a community rebuild chariots every year instead of keeping them?*

Map 3 min

Tap each numbered site on the screen as you speak.

#	SITE	WHERE	WHAT TO SAY
1	**Puri**	Odisha	Eastern Char Dham. Jagannath temple and the Rath Yatra chariot festival.
2	**Madurai**	Tamil Nadu	Meenakshi Amman temple at the heart of a city on the Vaigai river.
3	**Tiruvannamalai**	Tamil Nadu	Arunachaleswarar temple. A great lamp is lit on the hill for Karthigai Deepam.
4	**Pandharpur**	Maharashtra	Vitthal temple on the Bhima river; end point of the Wari walk.

Explore 9 min

Step 1 · Whole class (2–3 min)

Storyboard one festival route from start to finish.

ANSWER KEY

Matching game: Festival and feature

TERM	MATCH
Rath Yatra	Three wooden chariots rebuilt yearly
Chithirai Festival	A divine wedding joined with a river procession
Karthigai Deepam	A great lamp on Arunachala hill
Pandharpur Wari	A three-week walk singing abhangs

Map game: Festival map

Students tap each named site on the map: Puri, Madurai, Tiruvannamalai, Pandharpur.

Step 2 · Task (4–5 min)

> Choose one festival and plan its crowd management on the route map on your sheet. Mark entry points, medical stations, water points and how you'll communicate with the crowd. Then write two sentences explaining what the festival means to participants.

Prompts for groups that get stuck:

- Where will crowds be densest?
- How will emergency vehicles get through?
- How do you inform pilgrims who don't have phones?
- Which moments of the festival draw the biggest surge?

Step 3 · Discussion (2 min)

"Why might it matter that the Wari welcomes everyone regardless of caste? What does a procession say about who belongs?"

Look for: Processions show who belongs: when everyone can pull the chariot or walk the Wari, the boundaries of caste and class soften, at least for a time. Strong answers connect this to bhakti ideas of devotion over status.

Quiz 5 min

Students answer individually (fingers 1–4 or on the handout) before you reveal.

#	QUESTION	ANSWER	WHY
1	Which English word comes from Jagannath?	**A** Juggernaut	Through European accounts of the chariots.
2	Which saints' palkhis lead the Wari?	**C** Dnyaneshwar and Tukaram	Marathi bhakti saints.
3	What does the Chithirai Festival unite?	**C** Shaiva and Vaishnava festivals	Meenakshi's wedding and Kallazhagar's journey.
4	Why is the Wari socially significant?	**B** It is open to people of all castes	Bhakti emphasized devotion over status.

Reflect 3 min

Passport prompt: Explain why a sacred image might travel outside a temple, and what that reveals about community.

Model answer: *A sacred image travels outside the temple so that the whole community, including those who cannot enter, can have darshan, turning public streets into shared sacred space.*

Exit ticket: one word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

Next class: Sunday, March 7, 2027 — Class 16: Madurai Meenakshi and the Temple-City.

Teacher background

The Wari routes start from Alandi (Dnyaneshwar) and Dehu (Tukaram) near Pune. The Puri chariots are built by hereditary carpenters using traditional measurements, without modern blueprints.

Questions students may ask

"Why would people be hurt pulling chariots?"

Huge crowds and heavy chariots create danger; safety measures have improved but accidents still occur.

"Can non-Hindus attend the Rath Yatra?"

Yes, the street procession is public; entry to Puri's inner temple is restricted to Hindus.

Quick notes

- Next unit: southern and western temple landscapes.

Madurai Meenakshi and the Temple-City

OBJECTIVES — STUDENTS CAN:

1. Describe the Meenakshi Amman temple and its gopurams.
2. Explain the concentric plan of the old city of Madurai.
3. Analyze how worship and commerce reinforce each other.
4. Compare Madurai's plan with a planned city such as Washington, D.C.

TIMING

Wonder	3 min	0:00–0:03
Learn	7 min	0:03–0:10
Map	3 min	0:10–0:13
Explore	9 min	0:13–0:22
Quiz	5 min	0:22–0:27
Reflect	3 min	0:27–0:30

KEY TERMS

Nayak	NAA-yuk	dynasty that expanded the temple
mandala	MUN-da-la	sacred concentric diagram
kulam	KU-lam	temple tank

Materials: presentation (Class 16), student handout for Class 16, passports or notebooks, South Asia map.

Wonder 3 min

"What if a city's street plan were designed around a temple's festival calendar?"

> What if a whole city's street plan were designed around a temple and its festival calendar? Where would markets go? Where would homes go? Where would parades go?

Teacher move: Sketch concentric squares on the board as students answer; reveal that this is Madurai.

Learn 7 min

1. The temple

> The Meenakshi Amman temple in Madurai, on the Vaigai river in Tamil Nadu, honors the goddess Meenakshi, a form of Parvati, and her consort Sundareswarar, a form of Shiva. The site is ancient, but much of the present complex was built under the Nayak rulers in the 16th and 17th centuries.

2. Gopurams

> The temple has fourteen gopurams, gateway towers covered with thousands of brightly painted stucco figures of deities, animals and demons. The tallest rise above 50 meters. The figures are repainted during major renovations, so the temple always looks vividly new.

3. A mandala city

> Old Madurai is laid out in concentric squares of streets around the temple, like a mandala, a sacred diagram. The streets are named after Tamil months, such as Chithirai and Masi, and each month's festival procession

travels along its street. The city plan follows the festival calendar.

4. Temple and economy

Inside the walls are the Golden Lotus Tank, where devotees bathe, and the Thousand Pillar Hall, a mandapa with carved columns, now partly a museum. Outside, the streets are lined with flower sellers, tailors, brass shops and sweet makers. Worship brings customers, and commerce supports the temple: each sustains the other.

Check for understanding: *What is one advantage of a city designed around a festival calendar?*

Map 3 min

Tap each numbered site on the screen as you speak.

#	SITE	WHERE	WHAT TO SAY
1	**Madurai**	Tamil Nadu	Meenakshi Amman temple at the heart of a city on the Vaigai river.

Explore 9 min

Step 1 · Whole class (2–3 min)

Trace walls, gateways, markets and procession streets on the city map.

ANSWER KEY

Builder: Gopuram builder

Open-ended: students adjust tiers and colors and count the repeating shapes. Ask what makes a gopuram readable from far away.

Sort game: Inside the walls or the streets?

GROUP	CARDS THAT BELONG
Inside the temple	Golden Lotus Tank · Thousand Pillar Hall · Meenakshi's shrine
City streets around it	Month-named procession streets · Flower markets · Tailors and brass shops

Step 2 · Task (4–5 min)

Use the simplified Madurai plan on your sheet. Mark the temple, the gateways, one market and one procession street. Then explain in three sentences how the plan supports both worship and business, and compare it with Washington, D.C., which is planned around the Capitol and the National Mall.

Prompts for groups that get stuck:

- What sits at the exact center of each plan?
- Where do processions or parades go in each city?
- What message does each plan send about what matters most?
- Who designed each city, and when?

Step 3 · Discussion (2 min)

"What is lost and gained when a living temple-city becomes a major tourist destination?"

Look for: Tourism brings income and global attention, but can crowd out worshippers, raise prices and turn living practice into spectacle. Strong answers weigh local residents' and devotees' perspectives.

Quiz 5 min

Students answer individually (fingers 1–4 or on the handout) before you reveal.

#	QUESTION	ANSWER	WHY
1	Which dynasty built much of the present Meenakshi temple?	**D** The Nayaks	16th–17th centuries.
2	Madurai's street names come from…	**D** Tamil months	Each street hosts that month's festival.
3	Gopuram figures are made of…	**C** Painted stucco	Repainted during renovations.
4	The city plan resembles a…	**D** Mandala of concentric squares	The temple sits at the center.

Reflect 3 min

Passport prompt: Identify three design features of a gopuram and explain what each communicates to a visitor.

Model answer: *Gopurams stand out because of their great height, which makes the temple visible across the city; their bright colors, which draw attention; and their crowded figures, which tell stories to anyone passing by.*

Exit ticket: one word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

Next class: Sunday, March 14, 2027 — Class 17: Thanjavur, Chidambaram and Temple Arts.

Teacher background

The temple is in active worship and visited by tens of thousands daily. The Thousand Pillar Hall actually has about 985 pillars. Students can try the Gopuram Builder in the presentation.

Questions students may ask

"Are the figures on gopurams gods?"

Many are deities and divine beings; others are guardians, animals and scenes from stories.

"Why repaint them?"

Renovation, called kumbhabhishekam, renews the temple ritually and physically, often every 12 years.

Quick notes

- Students can use the gopuram builder to discuss repetition and proportion.
- DST begins Mar 14.

Thanjavur, Chidambaram and Temple Arts

OBJECTIVES — STUDENTS CAN:

1. Describe the Brihadisvara temple and its Chola context.
2. Interpret the symbolism of the Nataraja image.
3. Use inscriptions as historical evidence.
4. Evaluate arguments about repatriating sacred bronzes.

TIMING

Wonder	3 min	0:00–0:03
Learn	7 min	0:03–0:10
Map	3 min	0:10–0:13
Explore	9 min	0:13–0:22
Quiz	5 min	0:22–0:27
Reflect	3 min	0:27–0:30

KEY TERMS

lost-wax casting	—	molding metal from a wax model
ananda tandava	AA-nun-da TAN-da-va	dance of bliss
repatriation	ree-pay-tree-AY-shun	returning objects to their place of origin

Materials: presentation (Class 17), student handout for Class 17, passports or notebooks, South Asia map.

Wonder 3 min

“How can art be devotion, history and royal propaganda all at once?”

> How can a work of art be devotion, history and royal propaganda all at once? Think of a monument you know, like the Lincoln Memorial. What different jobs does it do?

Teacher move: Draw out that art can honor the sacred, record history and display power simultaneously. Today’s temple did all three.

Learn 7 min

1. Brihadisvara, Thanjavur

> The Brihadisvara temple in Thanjavur was completed around 1010 CE by the Chola king Rajaraja I. Its granite vimana rises about 66 meters, crowned by a huge stone cap. The Cholas ruled much of South India and sent naval expeditions across the Bay of Bengal. This temple, together with two later Chola temples, forms the UNESCO World Heritage Site of the Great Living Chola Temples.

2. Inscriptions as archive

> The temple's walls are covered with inscriptions. They record Rajaraja's gifts of gold, jewels and land, the villages that supported the temple, and the names and pay of hundreds of dancers, musicians, priests, accountants and craftsmen. For historians, these walls are an archive in stone, a rare look inside an 11th-century institution.

3. Nataraja

> At Chidambaram, Shiva is worshipped as Nataraja, Lord of the Dance. In the famous image, he dances within a ring of fire, holding a small drum that represents the sound of creation and a flame representing destruction. One hand is raised, palm out, meaning 'do not fear.' His foot rests on a small figure, Apasmara, representing ignorance. His dance, the ananda tandava, represents the cycles of the universe.

4. Chola bronzes

> Chola artists cast bronze images using the lost-wax method: a wax model is coated in clay, heated so the wax melts out, and filled with molten metal. These bronzes were carried in temple processions. Many are now in museums around the world, and several looted pieces have been returned to India in recent years, a process called repatriation.

Check for understanding: *Which detail of the Nataraja stands out most to you, and what might it mean?*

Map 3 min

Tap each numbered site on the screen as you speak.

#	SITE	WHERE	WHAT TO SAY
1	**Thanjavur**	Tamil Nadu	Brihadisvara temple, completed around 1010 CE by the Chola king Rajaraja I.
2	**Chidambaram**	Tamil Nadu	Nataraja temple, honoring Shiva as the Lord of the Dance.

Explore 9 min

Step 1 · Whole class (2–3 min)

Analyze a Nataraja image and a temple inscription.

ANSWER KEY

Matching game: Read the Nataraja

TERM	MATCH
Ring of fire	The cosmos and its cycles
Damaru drum	Sound of creation
Abhaya hand (raised palm)	Protection, "do not fear"
Fire in one hand	Destruction and transformation
Foot on the dwarf Apasmara	Overcoming ignorance
Raised foot	Release and grace

Step 2 · Task (4–5 min)

> Make a claim about how the Brihadisvara temple served Rajaraja's political power. Support it with two pieces of evidence from today: its scale, its inscriptions, its location in the capital, or anything else. Write it as a short paragraph.

Prompts for groups that get stuck:

- What does a 66-meter tower say to a visitor in 1010?
- Who is named in the inscriptions, and why?
- Why build it in the capital?
- How did the temple connect villages to the king?

Step 3 · Discussion (2 min)

"Should sacred bronzes in foreign museums be returned to India's temples? Consider ownership, worship and preservation."

Look for: For return: sacred objects belong in worship; many were stolen; communities have a right to their heritage. Against or complicating: preservation conditions, legal purchases long ago, global audiences. Strong answers distinguish looted objects from legally acquired ones.

Quiz 5 min

Students answer individually (fingers 1–4 or on the handout) before you reveal.

#	QUESTION	ANSWER	WHY
1	Who built Brihadisvara?	**A** Rajaraja Chola I	Completed around 1010 CE.
2	Why are its inscriptions valuable to historians?	**A** They record gifts, staff and pay	An archive in stone.
3	How were Chola bronzes made?	**C** Lost-wax casting	A wax model is replaced by metal.
4	What does repatriation mean?	**A** Returning objects to their place of origin	Several looted idols have been returned.

Reflect 3 min

Passport prompt: Make one claim about the Nataraja and support it with two visible details.

Model answer: *The Nataraja shows the cycle of creation and destruction: the drum in one hand represents creation, while the flame in another represents destruction.*

Exit ticket: one word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

Next class: Sunday, April 4, 2027 — Class 18: Rameswaram and the Sea.

Teacher background

Notable returns include Chola bronzes from Australian and US collections in the 2010s–2020s after investigations into the dealer Subhash Kapoor. Chidambaram's gopurams show 108 dance poses (karanas) from the Natyashastra.

Questions students may ask

"Is Nataraja only Hindu art?"

It is sacred Hindu imagery that has also become a global symbol; a statue stands at CERN in Switzerland.

"Did dancers really work in temples?"

Yes. Temple dance traditions fed into Bharatanatyam; the history of temple dancers is complex and later involved social reform.

Quick notes

- Spring break Mar 21 and 28. Next class Apr 4.

Rameswaram and the Sea

OBJECTIVES — STUDENTS CAN:

1. Describe Rameswaram's island setting and temple features.
2. Explain the Ramayana associations of the site.
3. Compare narrative and scientific descriptions of Adam's Bridge.
4. Evaluate the Sethusamudram debate from several perspectives.

TIMING

Wonder	3 min	0:00–0:03
Learn	7 min	0:03–0:10
Map	3 min	0:10–0:13
Explore	9 min	0:13–0:22
Quiz	5 min	0:22–0:27
Reflect	3 min	0:27–0:30

KEY TERMS

tirtham	TEER-tham	sacred water source
setu	SAY-too	bridge
shoal	SHOLE	shallow sandbank

Materials: presentation (Class 18), student handout for Class 18, passports or notebooks, South Asia map.

Wonder 3 min

"How does one place hold an epic story, a geological feature and a modern political debate?"

> How can one place hold an epic story, a geological feature and a modern political debate, all at once? Look at the map: a chain of sandbanks between India and Sri Lanka. What questions would different people ask about it?

Teacher move: Prompt three viewpoints: a devotee, a geologist and a shipping company. Record their questions.

Learn 7 min

1. An island temple town

> Rameswaram is a temple town on Pamban Island in the Gulf of Mannar, Tamil Nadu. It is linked to the mainland by a road bridge and a railway bridge; a new vertical-lift rail bridge opened in 2025, replacing the century-old Pamban bridge.

2. Ramanathaswamy

> The Ramanathaswamy temple, the southern dham and a Jyotirlinga, is famous for its long pillared corridors, often called the longest in India, with more than a thousand carved pillars. Inside are 22 tirthams, sacred wells; many pilgrims bathe with water from each before darshan.

3. Ramayana links

> In the Ramayana, Rama worships Shiva at Rameswaram before or after crossing to Lanka. One story tells that Hanuman was sent to bring a linga from Kailash; when he was delayed, Sita made a linga of sand. Both lingas

are worshipped in the temple today. Between India and Sri Lanka, a chain of shoals, or sandbanks, is known as Rama Setu, 'Rama's bridge,' or Adam's Bridge.

4. Science and debate

Geologists study the shoals as natural formations of sand and coral. In the 2000s, a proposed shipping canal called the Sethusamudram project would have dredged through them to shorten sea routes. It met religious objections that it would damage Rama Setu, and environmental concerns about coral reefs and fisheries in the Gulf of Mannar. The case went to India's Supreme Court and the project stalled.

Check for understanding: *Why might both a devotee and an environmentalist oppose the canal, for different reasons?*

Map 3 min

Tap each numbered site on the screen as you speak.

#	SITE	WHERE	WHAT TO SAY
1	**Rameswaram**	Tamil Nadu	Island temple town. Southern Char Dham with very long pillared corridors.

Explore 9 min

Step 1 · Whole class (2–3 min)

Compare a story map with a physical map of Rameswaram and the Palk Strait.

ANSWER KEY

Sort game: Story map or physical map?

GROUP	CARDS THAT BELONG
Narrative	Rama worships Shiva · Bridge built by Hanuman's army · Hanuman brings a linga from Kailash
Physical / scientific	Sandbanks across the Palk Strait · Pamban vertical-lift bridge · Coral reefs of the Gulf of Mannar

Step 2 · Task (4–5 min)

Evaluate the Sethusamudram debate. In groups of three, each person takes one position: economic, environmental or religious. Summarize your position and the evidence it relies on in two minutes. Then together, write one sentence on whether these positions can be reconciled.

Prompts for groups that get stuck:

- Economic: shorter shipping routes, fuel savings, port development.
- Environmental: coral reefs, dugongs, fishing communities.
- Religious: Rama Setu as a sacred site.
- What evidence does each side trust most?

Step 3 · Discussion (2 min)

"Can scientific and sacred descriptions of the same place coexist? How?"

Look for: Scientific and sacred descriptions answer different questions: how a formation came to be versus what it means. People can hold both. Strong answers avoid mocking either view.

Quiz 5 min

Students answer individually (fingers 1–4 or on the handout) before you reveal.

#	QUESTION	ANSWER	WHY
1	What is Adam's Bridge?	**A** A chain of shoals between India and Sri Lanka	Also called Rama Setu.
2	What was the Sethusamudram project?	**C** A proposed shipping canal through the shoals	It drew religious and environmental objections.
3	How many tirthams are inside Ramanathaswamy?	**B** 22	Pilgrims bathe in each.
4	Rameswaram is located on…	**A** Pamban Island	In the Gulf of Mannar.

Reflect 3 min

Passport prompt: Answer: how can one place connect several stories and kinds of knowledge? Use Rameswaram as evidence.

Model answer: *Rameswaram connects several kinds of knowledge: the Ramayana gives it sacred meaning, geology explains its sandbanks, and modern debates over the canal show how both shape decisions today.*

Exit ticket: one word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

Next class: Sunday, April 11, 2027 — Class 19: Hampi, Ellora, Khajuraho and Konark.

Teacher background

The Gulf of Mannar is a marine biosphere reserve. Sri Lanka lies about 30 km from Dhanushkodi at the tip of the island. Dhanushkodi was destroyed by a cyclone in 1964.

Questions students may ask

"Is Rama Setu man-made?"
Scientists generally describe it as a natural formation; for many devotees it is the bridge from the Ramayana. Present both.

"Can you walk to Sri Lanka?"
No; the shoals are partly submerged and the crossing is an international border.

Quick notes

- Next: Hampi, Ellora, Khajuraho, Konark.

Hampi, Ellora, Khajuraho and Konark

OBJECTIVES — STUDENTS CAN:

1. Describe Hampi, Ellora, Khajuraho and Konark and their builders.
2. Distinguish living temples from protected monuments.
3. Curate a mini-exhibit around a clear claim.
4. Debate who should decide the use of heritage sites.

TIMING

Wonder	3 min	0:00–0:03
Learn	7 min	0:03–0:10
Map	3 min	0:10–0:13
Explore	9 min	0:13–0:22
Quiz	5 min	0:22–0:27
Reflect	3 min	0:27–0:30

KEY TERMS

living temple	—	still used for worship
monument	—	protected historic structure
ASI	—	Archaeological Survey of India

Materials: presentation (Class 19), student handout for Class 19, passports or notebooks, South Asia map.

Wonder 3 min

"When a temple is no longer used for worship, is it still sacred, or is it now a monument?"

> When a temple is no longer used for worship, is it still sacred, or has it become a monument? Think about an old church that is now a museum. Does its meaning change?

Teacher move: Collect views on both sides. Introduce the terms 'living temple' and 'monument' on the board.

Learn 7 min

1. Hampi

> Hampi, in Karnataka, was the capital of the Vijayanagara Empire, which flourished from the 14th to 16th centuries. After the empire's defeat at the Battle of Talikota in 1565, the city was sacked and largely abandoned. Its ruins include the Vittala temple with its famous stone chariot. Yet the Virupaksha temple has remained in worship throughout.

2. Ellora

> Ellora, in Maharashtra, has 34 caves carved between about 600 and 1000 CE by Hindu, Buddhist and Jain communities, side by side. It shows how different traditions shared sacred landscapes. Its most famous cave, the Kailasa temple, we met in October.

3. Khajuraho

> Khajuraho, in Madhya Pradesh, was built by the Chandela kings between about 950 and 1050 CE. Of an estimated 85 temples, about 25 survive. Their sculptures show deities, celestial beings, musicians, warriors and

> scenes of daily life, with tall Nagara towers.

4. Konark

> Konark, on the Odisha coast, is the 13th-century Sun Temple built by King Narasimhadeva I of the Eastern Ganga dynasty. It is shaped as the chariot of Surya, the sun god, with 24 carved stone wheels and seven horses. Its main tower collapsed long ago, and worship there ended. All four sites are UNESCO World Heritage Sites, protected by the Archaeological Survey of India.

Check for understanding: *Which of the four sites would you call 'sacred' today, and why?*

Map 3 min

Tap each numbered site on the screen as you speak.

#	SITE	WHERE	WHAT TO SAY
1	**Hampi**	Karnataka	Ruins of the Vijayanagara capital. The Virupaksha temple is still a place of worship.
2	**Ellora**	Maharashtra	Hindu, Buddhist and Jain caves. The Kailasa temple was carved from one rock.
3	**Khajuraho**	Madhya Pradesh	Chandela-era temples (about 950–1050 CE) with tall, curved Nagara towers.
4	**Konark**	Odisha	13th-century Sun Temple shaped like the chariot of Surya, with 24 carved wheels.

Explore 9 min

Step 1 · Whole class (2–3 min)

Become curators: choose four images for a mini-exhibit.

ANSWER KEY

Matching game: Site and clue

TERM	MATCH
Hampi	Empire capital sacked in 1565
Ellora	Hindu, Buddhist and Jain caves together
Khajuraho	Chandela temples, about 25 survive
Konark	Sun temple shaped as a chariot

Map game: Find the sites

Students tap each named site on the map: Hampi, Ellora, Khajuraho, Konark.

Step 2 · Task (4–5 min)

> You are museum curators. Choose four of the eight image cards on your sheet for a mini-exhibit. Decide one claim your exhibit makes, about art, power or landscape. Write a 50-word wall label for each image that supports your claim.

Prompts for groups that get stuck:

- Art: what techniques and subjects stand out?
- Power: who paid for these, and what did they want to say?
- Landscape: how does the setting shape each site?
- Order your images to tell a story.

Step 3 · Discussion (2 min)

"Who should decide whether a protected monument can be used for worship again: archaeologists, devotees or the government?"

Look for: Archaeologists: preservation and scientific study. Devotees: worship and continuity. Government: law, tourism and politics. Strong answers recognize that some sites are protected precisely because they are fragile, and that 'living heritage' needs room to change.

Quiz 5 min

Students answer individually (fingers 1–4 or on the handout) before you reveal.

#	QUESTION	ANSWER	WHY
1	Which battle led to Hampi's fall?	**B** Talikota, 1565	The city was sacked afterward.
2	Ellora is notable for…	**A** Hindu, Buddhist and Jain caves side by side	Shared sacred space.
3	Which of these remains a living temple?	**B** Virupaksha, Hampi	Worship continues there.
4	Who built the Konark Sun Temple?	**A** Narasimhadeva I	13th century, Eastern Ganga dynasty.

Reflect 3 min

Passport prompt: State the one-sentence claim of your exhibit and defend your choice of images.

Model answer: *My exhibit claims that these temples were statements of royal power: Konark's chariot, Hampi's capital temples and Khajuraho's towers all display the wealth and ambitions of their kings.*

Exit ticket: one word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

Next class: Sunday, April 18, 2027 — Class 20: Beyond India: Bali, Cambodia and the Global Hindu World.

Teacher background

The Konark Sun Temple's wheels are often called sundials; some guides say they can tell time, but this is debated. Khajuraho's sculptures include erotic scenes; with teenagers, acknowledge briefly if asked and redirect to the overall program of the art.

Questions students may ask

"Why did Konark collapse?"
Causes are debated: structural weakness, sandy soil, possibly damage over time. It was filled with sand by the British in 1903 to stabilize it.

"Is it okay to worship at a monument?"

Rules vary by site; the ASI regulates protected monuments, and some allow existing worship to continue.

Quick notes

- Site Profile 2 due next week (Apr 18).

Beyond India: Bali, Cambodia and the Global Hindu World

OBJECTIVES — STUDENTS CAN:

1. Describe Balinese Hinduism and major Balinese temples.
2. Explain Angkor Wat's Hindu origins and later Buddhist use.
3. Analyze how ideas traveled across Southeast Asia.
4. Compare a historic site abroad with a US diaspora temple.

TIMING

Wonder	3 min	0:00–0:03
Learn	10 min	0:03–0:13
Explore	9 min	0:13–0:22
Quiz	5 min	0:22–0:27
Reflect	3 min	0:27–0:30

KEY TERMS

Agama Hindu Dharma	—	Balinese Hinduism
Meru	MAY-roo	cosmic mountain
diaspora	dye-AS-po-ra	communities living away from an ancestral homeland

Materials: presentation (Class 20), student handout for Class 20, passports or notebooks.

Wonder 3 min

"When a tradition travels, what stays the same and what changes?"

> When a tradition travels to a new land, what stays the same and what changes? Think about your own family's traditions here in the US. What did you keep exactly? What did you adapt?

Teacher move: Collect examples: food, language, festival dates moved to weekends, temple classes. Note that this has happened for two thousand years.

Learn 10 min

1. Bali

> On the Indonesian island of Bali, most people practice Agama Hindu Dharma, Balinese Hinduism, which blends Indic deities and epics with local ancestor and nature traditions. Pura Besakih, the 'Mother Temple,' stands on the slopes of the volcano Mount Agung. Tanah Lot sits on a rock in the sea and is cut off at high tide. Families make small daily offerings of flowers in palm-leaf trays called canang sari.

2. Angkor Wat

> In Cambodia, Angkor Wat was built in the early 12th century by King Suryavarman II of the Khmer Empire and dedicated to Vishnu. Its five towers represent Mount Meru, the mountain at the center of the cosmos in Hindu and Buddhist thought. Its galleries carry long reliefs from the Ramayana and Mahabharata and the churning of the ocean.

3. How ideas traveled

> Over time Angkor Wat became a Buddhist site, and it has been used for Theravada Buddhist worship for centuries. It now appears on Cambodia's national flag. This shows how a sacred place can change traditions while keeping its sacredness.

4. The diaspora

> How did Indic ideas reach Southeast Asia? Not mainly by conquest, but through trade along sea routes, royal courts that adopted Sanskrit, Brahmin advisers and Buddhist monks, beginning in the early first millennium CE. Today, Hindu temples stand from Trinidad to Fiji to Toronto to Virginia, each adapting architecture, language and calendars to new homes.

Check for understanding: *Why might a king in Cambodia choose to build a temple to Vishnu?*

Explore 9 min

Step 1 · Whole class (2–3 min)

Photo detective stations: gates, towers, nature and offerings.

ANSWER KEY

Sort game: Bali or Angkor Wat?

GROUP	CARDS THAT BELONG
Bali	Temple on a sea rock · Daily canang sari offerings · Mother Temple on a volcano
Angkor Wat	Towers representing Mount Meru · Built by Suryavarman II · Appears on a national flag

Step 2 · Task (4–5 min)

> Write a comparison of Angkor Wat and a Hindu temple in the US, such as one you know locally. Identify two continuities and two changes, and explain what caused each change: climate, materials, community needs, or laws.

Prompts for groups that get stuck:

- What deity is honored, and in what form?
- How is the building used beyond worship?
- What language is used in signs and classes?
- How are festivals scheduled?

Step 3 · Discussion (2 min)

"Angkor Wat is now a Buddhist site and a national symbol. Who does a sacred place belong to when its religion changes?"

Look for: Angkor belongs to Cambodia as a national symbol and to Buddhists who worship there today, while it remains part of Hindu history. Shared ownership is possible. Strong answers avoid claiming any single group owns it exclusively.

Quiz 5 min

Students answer individually (fingers 1–4 or on the handout) before you reveal.

#	QUESTION	ANSWER	WHY
1	Angkor Wat was first dedicated to…	**C** Vishnu	It later became Buddhist.
2	What is Agama Hindu Dharma?	**A** Balinese Hinduism	It blends Indic and local practice.
3	How did Indic religion reach Southeast Asia?	**A** Trade, royal courts and religious specialists	Over many centuries.
4	Angkor Wat's towers symbolize…	**D** Mount Meru	The center of the cosmos.

Reflect 3 min

Passport prompt: Turn in Site Profile 2. Write one example of continuity and one of change in Hindu sacred spaces abroad.

Model answer: *Continuity: both Angkor Wat and diaspora temples honor Vishnu with Indic architecture. Change: US temples add classrooms and community halls because they serve as cultural centers far from India.*

Exit ticket: one word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

Next class: Sunday, April 25, 2027 — Class 21: Temple Communities, Food and Service.

Teacher background

Collect Site Profile 2 today. Angkor Wat is part of the Angkor UNESCO World Heritage Site (1992). Prambanan in Java, a 9th-century Hindu temple complex, is another example to mention.

Questions students may ask

"Is Balinese Hinduism the same as Indian Hinduism?"

It shares deities, epics and ideas but has its own distinct rituals and calendar.

"Why is Angkor Wat on the flag?"

It is Cambodia's national symbol of its Khmer heritage.

Quick notes

- Show a world map for Bali and Cambodia.
- Profile 2 due today.

Temple Communities, Food and Service

OBJECTIVES — STUDENTS CAN:

1. Identify the many roles that sustain a temple community.
2. Explain seva and annadanam.
3. Plan respectful interview questions for a temple volunteer.
4. Discuss debates over hereditary and open temple roles.

TIMING

Wonder	3 min	0:00–0:03
Learn	10 min	0:03–0:13
Explore	9 min	0:13–0:22
Quiz	5 min	0:22–0:27
Reflect	3 min	0:27–0:30

KEY TERMS

seva	SAY-vaa	selfless service
annadanam	un-na-DAA-nam	gift of food
archaka	AR-cha-ka	temple priest

Materials: presentation (Class 21), student handout for Class 21, passports or notebooks.

Wonder 3 min

"Who makes a temple work, and whose labor goes unnoticed?"

> Who makes a temple work, and whose work goes unnoticed? Picture the temple at 5 a.m. before the doors open. Who is already there, and what are they doing?

Teacher move: List roles on the board. Ask which roles visitors see and which they never see: cleaners, cooks, accountants, flower growers.

Learn 10 min

1. Many roles

> Temples depend on many people. Priests, called archakas or pujaris, perform rituals. Cooks prepare prasad and meals. Musicians play at rituals and processions. Artisans carve, paint and repair. Cleaners, guards, accountants and administrators keep things running. Outside, flower sellers, sweet makers and shopkeepers earn their living from visitors. Neighbors live with the noise, crowds and blessings of festivals.

2. Seva

> Seva means selfless service. Many Hindus see volunteering at a temple, serving food, cleaning, teaching classes or parking cars, as a form of devotion. In the United States, most temples depend heavily on volunteers, including teenagers. Bal Gokul itself runs on seva.

3. Annadanam

> Annadanam, the gift of food, is a central practice in many temples. Large temples such as Tirumala serve free meals to tens of thousands of people every day. In many traditions, sharing a meal side by side, regardless of

background, expresses equality before the divine.

4. Hereditary roles and change

> Some temple roles, especially priesthood, have traditionally been hereditary, passed down within certain families. In recent decades, some Indian states have trained and appointed priests from a wider range of backgrounds, leading to court cases and debate. Supporters cite equality and opportunity; others emphasize tradition, ritual knowledge and community autonomy.

Check for understanding: *Which temple role would you be most interested in doing as seva, and why?*

Explore 9 min

Step 1 · Whole class (2–3 min)

Build a community web around a temple with role cards and yarn.

ANSWER KEY

Matching game: Roles and resources

TERM	MATCH
Archaka	Rituals, lamps and bells
Cook	Large kitchens and ingredients
Musician	Nadaswaram and drums
Flower vendor	Garlands and supply chains
Administrator	Budgets and records
Volunteer	Time and skills

Step 2 · Task (4–5 min)

> Draft five respectful questions you could ask a local temple volunteer about how their temple runs. Then sketch a community web: put the temple in the center and connect at least eight roles, adding the resources each needs and one challenge they face.

Prompts for groups that get stuck:

- Ask open questions: ‘How’ and ‘What’ rather than yes/no.
- Ask about time, skills and motivation.
- Avoid questions that ask them to speak for all Hindus.
- Include one question about challenges.

Step 3 · Discussion (2 min)

“Should temple roles be open to anyone trained for them, or follow tradition? Present both perspectives fairly.”

Look for: Fair presentation: tradition and ritual expertise matter to many communities; equal access matters to many others. Strong answers present both views without dismissing either, and note that practices vary by temple and state.

Quiz 5 min

Students answer individually (fingers 1–4 or on the handout) before you reveal.

#	QUESTION	ANSWER	WHY
1	What does seva mean?	**D** Selfless service	Central to many temple communities.
2	What is annadanam?	**D** Free shared meals	The gift of food.
3	What do US diaspora temples often rely on?	**D** Volunteers	Community members run classes, kitchens and festivals.
4	What debate surrounds some temple roles?	**A** Whether they should be hereditary or open	Tradition and equality are both at stake.

Reflect 3 min

Passport prompt: Explain why a sacred place needs many kinds of work, and name one form of labor people often overlook.

Model answer: *A sacred place needs many kinds of work because worship depends on food, cleanliness, safety, music and money; the accountants and cleaners are often overlooked.*

Exit ticket: one word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

Next class: Sunday, May 2, 2027 — Class 22–23: Etiquette, Heritage and Sustainable Pilgrimage.

Teacher background

Tamil Nadu and Kerala have appointed priests from non-Brahmin backgrounds in state-run temples; the issue has involved several court rulings. An optional guest volunteer is welcome; remind students no one represents all Hindus.

Questions students may ask

"Are priests paid?"
Many receive salaries from temple boards or trusts, plus offerings; arrangements vary widely.

"Can women be priests?"
In some traditions and many diaspora temples, women lead rituals; in others, priesthood is male. Practices are changing.

Quick notes

- An optional local temple guest is welcome; remind students no one represents all Hindus.
- Next: etiquette and stewardship.

Etiquette, Heritage and Sustainable Pilgrimage

OBJECTIVES — STUDENTS CAN:

1. Describe respectful visitor practices at Hindu temples.
2. Explain why entry and conduct rules vary and are sometimes contested.
3. Analyze environmental and heritage challenges at busy sacred sites.
4. Write a recommendation that names a trade-off.

TIMING

Wonder	3 min	0:00–0:03
Learn	10 min	0:03–0:13
Explore	9 min	0:13–0:22
Quiz	5 min	0:22–0:27
Reflect	3 min	0:27–0:30

KEY TERMS

stewardship	STOO-erd-ship	responsible care
overtourism	—	more visitors than a place can bear
intangible heritage	—	living practices, not buildings

Materials: presentation (Class 22–23), student handout for Class 22–23, passports or notebooks.

Wonder 3 min

"What does it mean to be a responsible visitor to someone else's sacred place?"

> What does it mean to be a responsible visitor to someone else's sacred place? Think about a time you visited a place where you didn't know the rules. How did you figure out what to do?

Teacher move: Draw out strategies: watch others, read signs, ask. Today combines two curriculum classes, so move quickly from etiquette to stewardship.

Learn 10 min

1. Respectful visits

> Common customs at Hindu temples include removing shoes, dressing modestly, keeping quiet near shrines, following photography rules, and accepting prasad with the right hand or both hands. Visitors should ask before joining any ritual. But customs vary widely: read the signs, watch others and ask a volunteer.

2. Who can enter

> Entry rules differ too. Some temples in India admit only Hindus to the inner areas, such as Puri's Jagannath temple and Guruvayur. Some have had gender restrictions; the Sabarimala case reached India's Supreme Court in 2018 and remains contested. Accessibility for disabled visitors, through ramps and assistance, is improving but uneven.

3. Rivers and mountains

> Busy sacred sites face serious environmental pressure. The Ganga carries sewage and industrial waste; India launched the Namami Gange clean-up program in 2014. Mountain shrines face plastic waste, traffic and erosion. Some sites have banned plastic, introduced registration or limited vehicle access.

4. Heritage management

> Heritage management is a balancing act. The Archaeological Survey of India and UNESCO protect monuments, but living temples need space for worship, festivals, renovation and change. The Kumbh Mela is recognized as intangible heritage: a living practice, not a building. Stewardship means caring for both.

Check for understanding: *Why might a rule that makes sense at one temple not make sense at another?*

Explore 9 min

Step 1 · Whole class (2–3 min)

Sort visitor choices, then run the heritage council: balance clean water, safe paths, local jobs, visitor numbers and conservation.

ANSWER KEY

Sort game: Visitor choices

GROUP	CARDS THAT BELONG
Respectful	Remove shoes where asked · Follow signs on photography · Accept prasad with care
Ask first	Photograph the inner shrine · Join a ritual
Not appropriate	Climb carvings for a selfie · Leave plastic by the river · Touch the murti uninvited

Step 2 · Task (4–5 min)

> First, sort the visitor choices on your sheet into respectful, ask first and not appropriate. Then join the heritage council: your group chooses one site and one problem, such as plastic, overcrowding or water pollution, and writes a one-page recommendation that names the trade-off and who bears its costs.

Prompts for groups that get stuck:

- Who benefits from your recommendation?
- Who pays, in money, time or access?
- Is it enforceable?
- How will pilgrims learn about it?

Step 3 · Discussion (2 min)

“Can a site be both a protected monument and a living place of worship? What has to give?”

Look for: Protected monuments and living worship can coexist when rules allow regular rituals while protecting fragile structures; conflict arises when renovation, crowds or new construction threaten old fabric. Strong answers give a concrete example.

Quiz 5 min

Students answer individually (fingers 1–4 or on the handout) before you reveal.

#	QUESTION	ANSWER	WHY
1	What is the best approach when rules are unclear?	**A** Read signs and ask a volunteer	Customs vary widely.
2	When was Namami Gange launched?	**A** 2014	A national river clean-up program.
3	Which is intangible heritage?	**D** The Kumbh Mela	A living practice.
4	A key tension in heritage management is…	**A** Protecting monuments while allowing living worship	Living temples change over time.

Reflect 3 min

Passport prompt: State your recommendation in one sentence and name its main trade-off.

Model answer: *Recommendation: ban single-use plastic at the Kedarnath trail with deposit-refund bottles; trade-off: higher costs for vendors and pilgrims in the first season.*

Exit ticket: one word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

Next class: Sunday, May 9, 2027 — Class 24: Capstone Workshop.

Teacher background

Handle entry-rule disputes factually and present multiple views. The 2018 Sabarimala judgment allowed women of all ages to enter; it was referred to a larger bench in 2019 and remains under review.

Questions students may ask

"Why can't non-Hindus enter some temples?"
Some temples preserve long-standing rules about who may enter the inner areas; others welcome all. Respect the host's rules.

"Is it rude to take photos?"
Outside, usually not; inside the shrine, often not allowed. Check signs or ask.

Quick notes

- Combines curriculum Classes 22 and 23.
- Handle entry-rule disputes factually and present multiple views.
- Capstone workshop next week. Exhibition at Annual Day, May 16.

Capstone Workshop

OBJECTIVES — STUDENTS CAN:

1. Plan an exhibit around a clear thesis.
2. Select and cite credible sources.
3. Apply respectful, accurate language using emic and etic framing.
4. Give and receive useful peer feedback.

TIMING

Wonder	3 min	0:00–0:03
Learn	10 min	0:03–0:13
Explore	9 min	0:13–0:22
Quiz	5 min	0:22–0:27
Reflect	3 min	0:27–0:30

KEY TERMS

thesis	THEE-sis	main claim
citation	sigh-TAY-shun	source credit
peer review	—	feedback from classmates

Materials: presentation (Class 24), student handout for Class 24, passports or notebooks.

Wonder 3 min

"What is the single claim you want a visitor to leave your exhibit believing?"

> What is the single claim you want a visitor to leave your exhibit believing? Say it in one sentence, to your partner, right now.

Teacher move: Listen for vague claims like 'Varanasi is interesting' and push for arguable ones like 'Varanasi's ghats show that a sacred place can also be a working city.'

Learn 10 min

1. The task

> Your task is a small museum exhibit about one sacred place, one pilgrimage route, or two connected sites. It will be displayed at Annual Day on May 16 for families and the community.

2. Formats

> Choose a format that suits your strengths: a poster, a model, an audio tour, a slideshow, a map book or an illustrated travel guide. Whatever the format, it must be clear to a visitor in about two minutes.

3. Requirements

> Requirements: a clear thesis; a location map; a short timeline; an architecture or landscape analysis; one present-day issue, such as crowding, environment or a heritage debate; credited images; and at least three credible, cited sources of different types.

4. Language and evidence

> Language matters. Use emic and etic framing: 'For many devotees…' and 'Historians note…'. Avoid claims about all Hindus. Credit every image and source. Credible sources include UNESCO, museum websites, university publications and the temple's own website for its beliefs and practices.

Check for understanding: *How would you use a temple's own website differently from a UNESCO page?*

Explore 9 min

Step 1 · Whole class (2–3 min)

Peer review in pairs: accuracy, respectful language, evidence and clarity.

ANSWER KEY

Checklist: Exhibit checklist

Checklist items: Clear thesis · Location map · Timeline · Architecture or landscape analysis · One present-day issue · Three credible sources, cited · Credited images · Respectful, accurate language.

Step 2 · Task (4–5 min)

> Check off every requirement on your checklist. Then trade exhibits with a partner. Give them one strength, one question and one specific fix. You have five minutes for checking and four for peer review.

Prompts for groups that get stuck:

- Is the thesis specific and arguable?
- Does every section support the thesis?
- Are all images credited?
- Is any sentence a claim about all Hindus?

Step 3 · Discussion (2 min)

"What makes a source credible for this project? Compare a UNESCO page, a temple website and a travel blog."

Look for: UNESCO: authoritative on heritage history. Temple website: authoritative on its own beliefs and schedule, emic perspective. Travel blog: personal experience, may be inaccurate. Students should match source to question.

Quiz 5 min

Students answer individually (fingers 1–4 or on the handout) before you reveal.

#	QUESTION	ANSWER	WHY
1	Which sentence best fits an exhibit label?	**A** "In this tradition, the river is honored as a goddess."	Specific and accurate.
2	Which source is most credible for site history?	**D** UNESCO World Heritage Centre	Use institutional and scholarly sources.
3	How should a temple's own website be used?	**A** As an emic source on beliefs and practices	Know each source's perspective.

4	A strong thesis is…	**D** A specific, arguable claim	Every element should support it.

Reflect 3 min

Passport prompt: Write your exhibit thesis and list your three sources.

Model answer: *Thesis: "Madurai shows that a temple can shape an entire city, from its street plan to its markets." Sources: UNESCO tentative list entry, a book chapter on Nayak architecture, and the temple's official website.*

Exit ticket: one word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

Next class: Sunday, May 16, 2027 — Class 25: Exhibition, Reflection and Synthesis.

Teacher background

Plan exhibit logistics for Annual Day: tables, easels, power for audio or slides, and a sticky-note station for visitor feedback.

Questions students may ask

"Can we use Wikipedia?"

As a starting point to find sources, but cite the original sources it points to.

"Can we work in pairs?"

Decide your policy in advance; pairs work well for larger formats like models.

Quick notes

- Exhibition at Annual Day, Sunday May 16.

Exhibition, Reflection and Synthesis

OBJECTIVES — STUDENTS CAN:

1. Present an exhibit to an authentic audience.
2. Synthesize examples from three regions to answer the course's central question.
3. Compare current thinking with the October thesis.
4. Articulate a principle for studying religion respectfully.

TIMING

Wonder	3 min	0:00–0:03
Learn	7 min	0:03–0:10
Map	3 min	0:10–0:13
Explore	9 min	0:13–0:22
Quiz	5 min	0:22–0:27
Reflect	3 min	0:27–0:30

KEY TERMS

tirtha	TEER-tha	sacred crossing
emic / etic	—	insider / outsider view
synthesis	SIN-the-sis	combining ideas into a whole

Materials: presentation (Class 25), student handout for Class 25, passports or notebooks, South Asia map.

Wonder 3 min

"What makes a place sacred? Compare your answer to the thesis you wrote in October."

> What makes a place sacred? You wrote an answer in October. Before you look at it, write your answer today. Then compare. What changed, and why?

Teacher move: Return the October thesis sentences. Give students one minute to compare silently before the exhibition opens.

Learn 7 min

1. Exhibition walk

> Today is the exhibition at Annual Day. Each student or team stands by their exhibit for part of the time and visits others for the rest. Visitors leave one compliment and one question on a sticky note.

2. Synthesis

> Synthesis: answer 'What makes a place sacred?' with examples from at least three regions, such as the Himalayas, the south and beyond India. Name one similarity and one difference across your examples.

3. Revisit your thesis

> Revisit your October thesis. Many students start with 'a beautiful or old place' and end with ideas about narrative, practice and community, or about how meaning is made and contested. Both are valid; reflect on

how your thinking grew.

4. Final reflection

Final reflection: something I learned, something I still wonder, and one principle for studying religion respectfully, such as ‘describe before judging’ or ‘no one speaks for all Hindus.’

Check for understanding: *Which exhibit today taught you something new, and what was it?*

Map 3 min

Tap each numbered site on the screen as you speak.

#	SITE	WHERE	WHAT TO SAY
1	**Varanasi (Kashi)**	Uttar Pradesh	Ancient city on the Ganga with stone ghats and the Kashi Vishwanath temple of Shiva.
2	**Kedarnath**	Uttarakhand	Shiva temple at about 3,580 m. One of the 12 Jyotirlingas.
3	**Dwarka**	Gujarat	Western Char Dham. Dwarkadhish temple of Krishna beside the Arabian Sea.
4	**Puri**	Odisha	Eastern Char Dham. Jagannath temple and the Rath Yatra chariot festival.
5	**Rameswaram**	Tamil Nadu	Island temple town. Southern Char Dham with very long pillared corridors.
6	**Madurai**	Tamil Nadu	Meenakshi Amman temple at the heart of a city on the Vaigai river.
7	**Kamakhya**	Assam	Goddess temple on Nilachal Hill above the Brahmaputra, in Guwahati.
8	**Konark**	Odisha	13th-century Sun Temple shaped like the chariot of Surya, with 24 carved wheels.
9	**Hampi**	Karnataka	Ruins of the Vijayanagara capital. The Virupaksha temple is still a place of worship.

Explore 9 min

Step 1 · Whole class (2–3 min)

Hold the exhibition walk at Annual Day. Families are welcome.

ANSWER KEY

Map game: Year in review map challenge

Students tap each named site on the map: Varanasi (Kashi), Kedarnath, Dwarka, Puri, Rameswaram, Madurai, Kamakhya, Konark, Hampi.

Step 2 · Task (4–5 min)

During the museum walk, visit at least four exhibits. Leave a compliment and a question at each. Back at your seat, write your synthesis paragraph.

Prompts for groups that get stuck:

- Choose examples from different regions.
- Use the three lenses: narrative, practice, community.
- Use one term from the year: tirtha, darshan, yatra, emic, etic.
- End with a sentence about what you still wonder.

Step 3 · Discussion (2 min)

"Which site this year challenged your assumptions the most, and why?"

Look for: Celebrate growth. Ask volunteers to share how their thesis changed.

Quiz 5 min

Students answer individually (fingers 1–4 or on the handout) before you reveal.

#	QUESTION	ANSWER	WHY
1	What did tirtha originally mean?	**A** A ford or river crossing	Our first word of the year.
2	Emic describes…	**B** The insider's perspective	Etic is the outsider's view.
3	Which site was carved from a single cliff?	**D** Kailasa temple, Ellora	Rock-cut architecture.
4	Who built the Brihadisvara temple?	**A** Rajaraja Chola I	Around 1010 CE.
5	Angkor Wat was first dedicated to…	**C** Vishnu	It later became Buddhist.

Reflect 3 min

Passport prompt: Final reflection: something I learned, something I still wonder, and one principle for studying religion respectfully.

Model answer: *Across Varanasi, Madurai and Angkor Wat, places become sacred through stories, repeated practice and the communities that sustain them; the difference is that Angkor's community changed from Hindu to Buddhist while staying sacred.*

Exit ticket: one word that describes today's place, and one question you still have.

Close the year: congratulate students and stamp the final passport page.

Teacher background

This session runs within the Annual Day event. Set up exhibits before families arrive and assign student hosts in shifts. Stamp the final passport page.

Questions students may ask

"Will there be prizes?"
Decide in advance; many teachers prefer certificates for all and 'visitor choice' recognition.

Quick notes

- Runs as part of Annual Day. Set up exhibits before families arrive.
- Congratulate students and stamp the final passport page.